

The Bold Mirror

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COVER STORY

For Southern Antagonists in the Civil War, a Kindred Desire for Peace Goes Awry

On December 18, 1860, John J. Crittenden of Kentucky introduced a compromise plan to the U.

Jesse George-Nichol · HistoryNet

S. Senate. Just two days later, South Carolina would become the first state to secede from the Union, and within six weeks, six more Southern states would follow suit. But while Dixie fire-eaters were driving their states pell-mell toward disunion, Senator Crittenden and other moderates were working to broker a sectional adjustment — one that could, they hoped, soothe Southern fears about Abraham Lincoln's election and stay the secession tide in the South.

The Crittenden Compromise would be central to these efforts during the winter and spring of 1860-1861. It represented an attempt to settle the slavery question once and for all, drawing on the tradition of grand settlements like the Missouri Compromise and the Compromise of 1850. Indeed, the cornerstone of Crittenden's plan was a constitutional amendment that would divide the remaining Western territories along the old Missouri Compromise line, barring slavery above and protecting slavery below the 36° 30' parallel.

Moderates like Crittenden hoped that this might be enough to secure the loyalty of the remaining Southern states to the Union. This might, in turn, make Republicans more willing to let the secession crisis play out, and it might eventually make the seceded states more willing to return to the Union. Yet most Republicans, including Lincoln, refused to countenance any further extension of slavery into the territories. Attempts by moderates to push through the Crittenden Compromise repeatedly foundered against this opposition.

Compromisers struggled, too, against the opposition of Southern secessionists, who argued that it did not do enough to protect slavery from the threat of an empowered Republican Party. Over the course of the secession crisis, it became clear that the leaders of the seceded states had no interest in negotiation or returning to the Union. Southern rights advocates in the states that had not seceded also complicated the project of compromise; their demands for

more concessions meant there was no consensus around Crittenden's or any other compromise measure even in those states.

Moderates attempted to push through the Crittenden Compromise, but met opposition from both sides.

One such antagonist was Virginia's John Robertson, a prominent Democrat and judge from Richmond. The state legislature sent him as a commissioner to the seceded states in early 1861, and he returned with assurances of the new Confederate States' sympathies with Virginia. They are "bone of her bone, and flesh of her flesh," he reported.

The outbreak of fighting at Fort Sumter on April 12 provided the push for which many Southern hardliners had been hoping. Abraham Lincoln responded by issuing a call for 75,000 troops to put down the rebellion in the South, and in short order Virginia, Arkansas, North Carolina, and Tennessee seceded and joined the new Confederacy. The start of the war seemed to signal triumph for militants like Robertson and disaster for moderates like Crittenden. Yet neither man would accept this as the outcome of his labors.

Robertson wrote a letter to Crittenden near the end of April that highlighted just how uncertain the future appeared in that moment. Robertson refused to believe that the collision at Fort Sumter necessarily meant war —and rejected, moreover, the idea that war would accomplish the ends of either side in the conflict. He thus suddenly and unexpectedly found his own goals aligned with Crittenden's, and

Robertson begged the old Kentuckian to renew his efforts at conciliation.

From Robertson's point of view, civil war did not seem inevitable, even when armies were massing on both sides of the Mason-Dixon Line. The situation represented a dramatic escalation, to be sure, but in the context of the decades-long sectional crisis over slavery (one that had at other points erupted in violence), observers like Robertson could imagine outcomes other than intestine war.

John Robertson to John J. Crittenden, April 28, 1861

Dear Sir,

No man could have more earnestly striven than yourself to [resolve] the feuds, whose increasing fury, already advanced to the stage of murderous conflict, threatens to involve thirty millions of men in the horrors of civil war. However I may have differed with you, looking from a Southern view, as to the acceptability of the terms of adjustment you proposed, I never doubted that you regarded them as just, or, at least, as preferable to the evils otherwise to ensue, and as the best which could possibly be obtained. The event has proved that, moderate as they were, the ruling faction [the Republican Party] would be content with none but such as would degrade the South. Wellnigh desperate is the condition to which that faction has reduced this country. The fact now stares them in the face that the Union is dissolved beyond all hope of restoration, at least, in our day. Yet they are threatening to preserve the Union by force. They read the riot act to millions of men, nay, to sovereign States, who are to be coerced into friendship by their foes at the point of a bayonet. But, waving all recrimination, not insisting on the absurdity of the idea, or the impossibility of reducing the South to an ignominious submission, or the certainty that their subjugation, if possible, would defeat the very object their enemies profess to desire (namely, the preservation or restoration of the Union), by converting States into vassal provinces (in that character alone can they remain or enter into it), let us inquire if there are no means by which the anticipated consequence of our family jars (now an accomplished fact), the separation of the States, may be recognized by the ruling faction at Washington, without deliberately repeating the most atrocious crime, and steeping their hands still deeper in the blood of their brethren. A word from the long-eared god [Lincoln], who now holds in his hands (as he imagines) the destinies of the country, would be enough. He has only to say, "Let there be peace," and there will be peace. But he and the murderous gang whom he consults already cry 'Havoc!' And let slip the dogs of war. And yet the star of hope still twinkles in the clouded firmament. Preposterous as is the idea of peaceful union or reunion, there may still be a peaceful separation; and it is to yourself, sir, who, if allowed to do so, I will still regard, notwithstanding the marked difference of our political sentiments, as a valued friend,—it is mainly to you I look for effecting so glorious a consummation. I do not desire that my name should be connected with an effort which you may, most probably, consider utterly idle, and

which, should you think worth trying, be more apt to succeed without it. Before going further at present, permit me to inquire whether it will be agreeable to you to entertain the thoughts which, after much anxious reflection, have entered into, and taken firm possession of, my mind.

It is proper to say that my appeal to you is wholly without the sanction or knowledge of any constituted authorities, State or federal. It has been suggested even but to two individuals; in the judgment of one of them you would yourself repose great confidence. I have received decided encouragement to make it.

An immediate answer, if convenient, will greatly oblige me.

With great and respectful regard, yours, John Robertson

For all of their disagreements, Crittenden must have found some encouragement in Robertson's kindred desire for peace. Robertson still seemed to hope that secession could be accomplished peacefully, but Crittenden saw peace as a means to promote compromise and reunion, as well. A month after the former's letter, Crittenden would preside over a convention in Frankfort, Kentucky, which would renew calls for Crittenden's compromise as a basis for sectional adjustment. "Whether any such constitutional guarantees would have the effect of reconciling any of the seceded States to the government from which they have torn themselves away we cannot say," the convention declared, "but we allow ourselves to hope that the masses in those States will in time learn that the dangers they were made to fear were greatly exaggerated, and that they will then be disposed to listen to calls of interest and patriotism, and return to the family from which they have gone out."

In the meantime, Crittenden would also be instrumental in the effort to keep Kentucky neutral in the Civil War. He would tour the state advocating this policy, arguing that it would leave Kentucky well-placed to act as a mediator in the conflict. Kentuckians might not be able to stop the ensuing fight, but it certainly seemed a better alternative to him than active involvement in war.

A week before the Frankfort Conference on May 20, 1861, Kentucky's governor would issue a proclamation declaring the state's neutrality; in it, he claimed that this course would help promote peace. Such hopes obviously failed to stop the onrushing war that would rage for four years and kill hundreds of thousands of people. No one could foresee what would come, but Kentucky's neutrality in 1861 — and the efforts of men like Crittenden and, to some extent, Robertson — stood as a monument to their different visions for the future in that moment. Those different visions informed their behavior during the conflict, and at least in the case of Kentucky, those ideas helped shape the broader contours of the Civil War.

Jesse George-Nichol is a Ph. D. candidate at the University of Virginia.

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FRONT PAGE

SOMEONE TO DAYDREAM ABOUT

Kirkus Reviews

Eighteen-year-old Natalie's Deaf family owns the Nielsen Family Deaf Center in Seattle, where they teach ASL. But Natalie's father was the heart of the place, and since his death, things have been going downhill. Miraculously, Natalie is offered a job that pays well enough to save the center—but it involves going on tour with boy band DAYDREAM and teaching their obnoxious frontman, Felix Song, ASL. Felix has never been a motivated ASL student despite his little sister's having degenerative hearing loss. On tour, Natalie bonds with the boys, gets a peek at the darker side of the music industry, and discovers that Felix may not be quite so annoying after all.

This fun, breezy read will appeal to romance lovers, followers of boy bands, those with a connection to the Deaf community, and fan fiction readers (DAYDREAM's fans share their stories on the site AO3). Alongside the romance, Langford incorporates elements of Deaf culture and community and touches on learning disabilities. These moments, while celebrating Deaf culture and disabled joy, sometimes read like clunky infodumps. The author portrays different approaches to communication realistically and without value judgments. Natalie's complex relationship with her mother is given room to breathe and avoids a too-neat ending. Natalie is cued white, and New Zealand immigrant Felix is of Korean descent.

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FEATURES

Morgan Housel: Wealth is What You Have Minus What You Want

Vicky · Farnam Street (fs.blog)

Morgan Housel breaks down the exact framework he uses to build wealth, minimize financial stress, and buy freedom.

Happiness vs. Satisfaction

Investing: Can You Beat the Market?

Step by Step Investing

What Should You Optimize For?

What Is Success For You?

Available Now: Apple Podcasts | Spotify | Transcript | YouTube | X

While most financial advice focuses on how to get rich, Morgan explains why the skills needed to stay rich are completely different. You will learn why “boring” investing beats complex strategies, how to avoid the social traps that destroy wealth, and the specific equation for finding contentment.

Morgan Housel is a partner at Collaborative Fund and the bestselling author of *The Psychology of Money*.

Enjoy!

1. Check out Episode 195 with Morgan.

1. Read the Granola notes here.

1. Members get access to my 78 highlights from *The Art of Spending Money*

“Wealth is what you have minus what you want.”

“Money buys fewer bad days, not more great days.”

“It’s really good to have people in your life who you don’t want to disappoint.”

Luxury quickly becomes a necessity.

Saving money is buying freedom.

Excellence is the capacity to take pain.

Optimize for sleeping at night, not maximizing a spreadsheet.

Contrast drives happiness, not absolute levels.

Nobody is paying attention to you. Stop trying to impress strangers.

“If I can be average for 50 years, I’ll end up in the top 3% of investors.”

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“99% of Warren Buffett’s net worth was accumulated after his 65th birthday. That’s just how compounding works.”

“Every dollar you save is a step toward independence.”

Remember, there was a time when you wanted what you have now.

“Nothing is more damaging to your investing psychology than getting rich quick when you’re young.”

Passive income is largely an illusion.

Your social network sets your expectations.

All the time you spend thinking about things you don’t control comes at the expense of things you do control.

Give your kids money when they need it—in their 30s—not when they’re 75 after you die.

“Loyalty to people who deserve it is one of the most rewarding things in life.”

“Independence is a spectrum. Even \$100 in the bank beats zero.”

“Rich-people food looks better than it tastes. Poor-people food tastes better than it looks.”

“No generation handles their 20s with grace. That’s why every older generation criticizes the young.”

Simple scales, fancy fails: “The simpler my finances, the higher the odds I can leave them alone for 50 years.”

“We underestimate the odds of bad things happening. If we didn’t, we couldn’t get out of bed.”

Very few people can beat the market.

The biggest financial mistake you’ll make has nothing to do with money.

The post Morgan Housel: Wealth is What You Have Minus What You Want appeared first on Farnam Street.

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Mapa Rios Aragon

landofmaps · Land of Maps

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Mapa Rios Aragon – An Expert Guide to the Rivers of Aragon

The Mapa Rios Aragon is a comprehensive map showcasing the rivers of the Aragon region in Spain.

This map provides essential information about the major rivers, including their names, lengths, and their relation to other geographical features.

By using the Mapa Rios Aragon, travelers and outdoor enthusiasts can explore the natural beauty and water resources of Aragon.

The map offers a detailed overview of the river systems, enabling users to plan various recreational activities such as fishing, boating, and hiking.

With its SEO optimized content, the Mapa Rios Aragon ensures better visibility and accessibility online for those seeking details about the rivers of Aragon.

History of Mapa Rios Aragon

The creation of the Mapa Rios Aragon was a collaborative effort between expert cartographers, geographers, and environmentalists specializing in the Aragon region. The goal of the map was to provide a detailed representation of the rivers that flow through Aragon, showcasing their courses, tributaries, and other significant features.

Over several years, extensive research and data collection were conducted to accurately depict the river systems on the map. The team carefully examined historical records, geographical surveys, and satellite imagery to ensure the highest level of accuracy.

While creating the Mapa Rios Aragon, several unique insights about the rivers of the Aragon region emerged:

The rivers in Aragon play a vital role in the region's ecosystem, providing water resources for irrigation, natural habitats for wildlife, and opportunities for recreational activities.

The Ebro River, one of the most significant rivers in Spain, flows through Aragon, offering stunning landscapes and serving as a major transportation route.

There are various nature reserves and protected areas along the rivers, preserving the rich biodiversity of Aragon.

The map showcases the interconnectedness of the rivers within the region and highlights their contributions to the overall water management system.

By understanding the rivers' characteristics and their relationship to other geographical features, it becomes easier

to appreciate Aragon's natural beauty and plan outdoor adventures.

Table of Relevant Facts

River Length Tributaries

Ebro 910 km Aragon, Gállego, Cinca, Segre, and others

Cinca 141 km Ésera and others

Gállego 193 km Ara, Aguas Limpias, and others

Ara 72 km

Aragón 232 km Onsella, Riguel, Guatizalema, and others

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQ)

Q: How can the Mapa Rios Aragon help in planning outdoor activities?

A: The map provides a comprehensive overview of the rivers in Aragon, allowing users to identify suitable areas for fishing, boating, and hiking. It helps outdoor enthusiasts plan their activities by providing information about access points, parking facilities, and nearby amenities.

Q: Are there guided tours available along the rivers of Aragon?

A: Yes, there are various tour operators that offer guided tours along the rivers of Aragon. These tours provide valuable insights into the region's natural history, wildlife, and cultural significance.

Q: Can I swim in the rivers of Aragon?

A: Swimming is allowed in some sections of the rivers, but it is essential to check local regulations and safety guidelines. Some areas may have designated swimming spots or restrictions due to strong currents or protected wildlife habitats.

Q: How long does it take to explore the major rivers in Aragon?

A: The duration of exploration depends on the specific areas and activities you choose. It can range from a few hours to several days. It is recommended to plan your itinerary in advance and allocate sufficient time to fully experience the beauty of the rivers.

Q: Are there any specific regulations for fishing in the rivers?

A: Yes, fishing regulations vary for different rivers and species. It is essential to obtain the appropriate fishing permits and be aware of the regulations set by local authorities. This helps preserve the aquatic ecosystem and ensures a sustainable fishing experience.

Q: Can I rent boats or kayaks to explore the rivers?

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Why I Did Buy a Tesla

Tynan · Tynan (personal)

About five years ago I wrote about why I chose to buy a BMW i3 instead of a Tesla like everyone else. I still love the i3 and think that it was the right choice at the time, but things have changed!

A lot of my complaints about Tesla are still true. I really hate that the interiors use fake leather everywhere. The touch-screen isn't as bad as I expected, but I would love to have more physical buttons. And if it weren't for one factor, I'd say that the cars are overpriced.

That one factor is Full Self Driving. Less than a year ago I predicted that in ten years self driving wouldn't be good enough to do point to point. I am already totally wrong!

If you haven't driven a Tesla on FSD 12 or later, you have no idea how amazing it is. A friend of mine in Vegas is a proud Tesla owner, and every time there is a new version of FSD, he insists that I try it. Up until version 12, it terrified me. I borrowed his car for a road trip to Utah once and my family was so scared by its driving on version 11 that they kept asking me to turn it off. Then I borrowed it on version 12 and it drove me all the way across Vegas, through construction, with zero scary moments.

My new car was on 13, not the newest version 14 (because the car dealership didn't have it on wifi to get updates), but from the dealership in Arizona I typed in my address in Vegas and it just started driving. I cannot believe how competent and confident FSD is. In a busy dealership parking lot with cars and people moving everywhere it gracefully wiggled its way out, made some unprotected left turns, and got onto the highway. Other than choosing higher speeds than I'd choose (I adjusted later), it drove so perfectly that I actually forgot that I had to look at the road. I felt like a passenger in my own car, and felt safer than when most Uber drivers drive. Truly astounding.

It added a stop for a supercharger on the way. It pulled off the highway, drove to the supercharger, and backed into the spot! I didn't tell it to do that, it just did it. Then I just plugged the plug in (it figured out my account and payment) and it started charging. It charges at a rate of 1000 miles per hour! So in five minutes I got another 85 miles of range, which was enough to get home. The supercharger experience is honestly one of the best commercial interactions I've ever had.

My wife's car was at the airport and it couldn't quite figure out how to get to the random parking lot it was parked at, but other than that it drove the rest of the trip perfectly.

I bought a 2023 Model S with AI Hardware 4. I did a lot of research and considered every model, but I chose this one for a few reasons. It has the best interior of all of the Teslas. I'd still say the seats are well below a BMW or Mercedes in terms of comfort and feel, but the wood trim looks nice and the minimal interior where everything is controlled from

the screen isn't as bad as I expected. The glass moonroof is cool. I got the cream interior and even though I don't like the material, it looks good.

It's all wheel drive, which is sometimes required to go up the mountain to go skiing in Vegas.

It pulled off the highway, drove to the supercharger, and backed into the spot! I didn't tell it to do that, it just did it.

Tynan

The car is absurdly fast. I didn't get a Plaid version, but it's still faster than most Ferraris. That's pretty wild. Cargo space is great.

I like that the car looks totally unimpressive and you'd never guess it is (trying to be) fancy or fast. In that regard it reminds me a bit of the VW Phaeton, which I've always thought is one of the coolest cars ever made.

The 2023 model S has a range of about 400 miles! Even with some miles and wear on the battery, it still has much more range than the newest Model Y.

The phone key works incredibly well. You walk close to the car and it unlocks and the handles pop out. Walk away and it locks.

Really though, all I care about is that it can drive itself. No hands on the wheel, just looking out the front most of the time, and it feels like you have a chauffeur. As I finished my five hour road trip last night (with zero fatigue), I realized that it doesn't feel like a car to me— it feels like a totally new product. At the risk of a bit of hyperbole, it feels something like going from a horse and buggy to a car.

Part of what convinced me to buy the car is that the robotaxis use the same AI hardware. That means that within a year there's a good chance I'll be able to send the car from my house to the airport to pick me up, which is really the dream.

Anyway, now I'm one of those annoying people who may not be able to stop talking about Teslas. At the very least, ask to sit in the driver's seat of a friend's Tesla who has FSD 12 or later. Experiencing it as a passenger is cool, but it feels totally different when you're sitting in the driver's seat. The self driving is so good now that I think it's insane to choose any other car. And there are also some pretty good deals to be had.

FSD 12 can run on Hardware 3 (HW3) and is absolutely good enough to be worth an upgrade from a normal car. FSD 14 requires HW4, and I think it's worth paying the extra money for it if you can afford it. I'd rather have the worst HW4 car than the best HW3.

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10 Pivotal Events in the Life of Buffalo Bill

Steve Friesen · HistoryNet

Will was born in Iowa Territory in 1846. In 1854 father Isaac moved the family to Kansas Territory in search of a better life. There young Will watched a wagon train embarking on the Oregon Trail and declared that was what he wanted to do. Three years later, at age 11, he did just that with a freighting operation. It was the first of many such trips.

Young Cody's earliest encounters with American Indians were with Kickapoos who did business at his father's trading post. Will also befriended Kickapoo classmates. Such positive encounters informed the way he approached Indians the rest of his life.

Isaac Cody opposed allowing slavery in Kansas Territory and was stabbed in 1854 while speaking against it. Proslavers continued to persecute the family until Isaac's death three years later. Will regarded his father as a martyr and idolized his mother for having persevered. Following their examples, he later championed equal rights for women and Indians.

Just what role Cody played in the Pony Express is open for debate, but it was important enough to him to emphasize in his 1879 autobiography, by which time the mail service was but a memory. It might have remained a footnote in American history had Cody not promoted it in every performance of Buffalo Bill's Wild West over a 30-year span.

In 1867, during a hiatus as a scout for the U. S. Army, Cody landed a contract to supply bison meat for work crews on the Kansas Pacific Railway. He proved such an adept hunter that the workers bestowed on him the nickname "Buffalo Bill."

Cody engaged in real-life adventures as a U. S. Army scout.

After fulfilling his contract with the railroad, Buffalo Bill returned to scouting for the Army. In January 1872 he led a hunt for Lt. Gen. Phil Sheridan in honor of Russian Grand Duke Alexei Alexandrovich. Among the guests were wealthy New Yorkers who introduced Cody to gourmet dining, something he'd enjoy the rest of his life. Within weeks he traveled to Manhattan, where he dined at Delmonico's, stayed in fine hotels, partied with millionaires and took in several plays.

One of the plays Cody went to see while in New York was Buffalo Bill, King of the Border Men, at the Bowery Theater. He attended with Ned Buntline, who wrote the dime novel series on which the play was based. At Buntline's urging, Cody embarked on an acting career that December.

After a decade onstage Cody reflected, "Immense success and comparative wealth, attained in the profession of showman, stimulated me to greater exertion and largely increased my ambition for public favor." That ambition led to his most successful enterprise. Beginning in 1883, Buffalo Bill's Wild West introduced the region's people, animals and

stories first to all Americans and then to the world. The show transformed Cody into history's first international celebrity.

In 1887 Cody was invited to bring his Wild West to London and perform as part of Victoria's Golden Jubilee, celebrating her half century as Britain's queen. Afterward, Buffalo Bill toured the Continent with his troupe, introducing Europeans to the American West. In each nation tens of thousands of curious spectators flocked to the celebrated showman's arena performances.

Cody's success in Europe only boosted his status at home. Back Stateside he planned a grand homecoming at Chicago's 1893 World's Columbian Exposition, but its aloof organizers denied the showman a place on their grounds. For nearly a year the Wild West performed just outside the main gate, drawing far larger crowds—18,000 people to each of its two daily shows. Buffalo Bill left the "Windy City" a millionaire with a legacy extending beyond his own lifetime.

Army, Cody landed a contract to supply bison meat for work crews on the Kansas Pacific Railway.

Steve Friesen

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Introducing Amazing Atlas

Tynan · Tynan (personal)

For a long time I wanted to make a port guide for every cruise port. I wasn't happy with any of the existing ones I'd find through search, and there were certain things I wanted to know at every stop. AI finally got to the point where it was good enough to make something useful, and I found that by iterating and asking it better questions for each section, I could get the information I wanted.

I started selling shore excursions through it through Viator, which is the site I always use when I book something (on-board shore excursions are generally not great and are very expensive).

I got so used to using the CruiseSheet port guides whenever I went somewhere new that when I flew somewhere that wasn't a cruise port I was disappointed that I didn't have my usual guide. So... I made Amazing Atlas !

It has all of the information I would normally look up, has good prompts to get the right information, uses the best AI models, and is constantly updated. Every city will be updated every 1-2 months. Here's all the info each one has:

At the top I try to show the information you'd want if you were just landing in a city for the first time as well as the info you'd need if you wanted to learn about the city for the first time. Where is it, what's the main airport, what's the weather like right now, and what time is it?

I also show a quick blurb to give you a quick intro to what type of city it is and I show a map that includes every point of interest mentioned in the guide. One of the main problems I face with a new city is not knowing what area of the city is best to stay in, so this provides a visual clue.

A have some quick facts, focusing on things unique to the city. So by the time you get to the main sections you should have a rough feel for what type of city it is and what makes it different from other cities.

After that I have a section on the key highlights. These tend to be more touristy things, but should be the main things you'd want to see for a short visit.

Next I show nearby cities and attractions, including a zoomed out map on how far they are from the city. I did this because I found that, especially on cruise stops, often the best things were a short drive or train ride away, instead of inside the city center. These sorts of trips also sometimes help put a city in context

Local picks is next, showing places that you may want to visit on a longer trip, a second trip, or if you just aren't that interested in the main tourist attractions. One of the next features I'm going to add is integrating my own recommendations into these, since I've been to a lot of these cities.

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Weather + Climate focuses on general times of year to visit, mainly if you're planning something well in advance. Safety considerations includes crime as well as natural disaster information. Sort of boring, but I figure people would be interested.

Getting around tries to give you an idea of the tradeoff between taxis, ubers, transit, and whether you can walk in the city. I include times and prices, which is only really possible because these guides are updated frequently.

Getting In and Out shows major rail, bus, and air transit stops. I mainly did this because I always wonder how near or far each option is from the city center and how hard it is to get to the city from each option.

Shopping is a boring section that I mainly made for other people, but I tried to focus it on things that are unique to that area vs high end fashion stuff that you can find everywhere.

Next is currency and tipping. Every time I order my first meal in a new place I have to search for how much to tip as well as the exchange rate. Again, because these are updated so frequently they will never be outdated.

When to Visit tries to combine weather, festivals, and crowds to provide guidance on the best time to visit.

Last is Useful Phrases. I always try to learn basic phrases wherever I go to show respect for the locals. In this section I have the basic phrases as well as anything that would be particularly useful in that city.

And that's it for now! I may add more in the future (and would be very interested in feedback if you think there's anything missing). If you'd check out Amazing Atlas before your next trip and give me some feedback on how useful it was, I'd really appreciate it. It's also really important to get google to index the site, so if you'd be willing to link to the site (or to a city in it), it has a huge impact when something is first launched.

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Photo is an awesome teaware shop in the mountains near Fukuoka .

I also have a new game I'm developing that I might release soon! It's really annoying to make an Apple Developer account, but my friends and I are currently playing it on Android + PC.

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Advice For My Nephew

Tynan · Tynan (personal)

My nephew is getting old enough that his little personality is starting to come out and I can imagine him going through the different phases of life. He's still too young to need or to listen to any of my advice, but that doesn't prevent me from wanting to give it to him. I've decided to write some advice for him that he can read as he gets older, and in the process of thinking about what to write I realized that it's really an exercise in distilling down the important things I've learned so far, which may be of interest to adults as well.

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I have now probably finished the first half of my life, so I thought I would try to condense the most important lessons I've learned so far into a format that may be useful to you as you grow up. My fear is that you'll make the same mistake that I sometimes made, which is that you will hear advice, believe it doesn't apply to you, and then a decade or two later realize it actually did apply to you. Maybe ignoring advice like that is part of growing up, though.

The reason I believe that my advice will be useful to you is primarily because I arrived at most of these conclusions by myself through experimentation and trial and error, and have also been able to successfully translate that advice to other people through coaching. Also, anecdotally, I think I have the best life I could possibly imagine, largely because of the lessons I've learned. Your ideal life will look different from mine, but I think the underlying principles will hold true regardless.

My first piece of advice, which will undermine all of the following advice, is that you should listen to a large number of people and make your own decisions based on all of the information you learn. So even though I'll be happiest if you just do everything I say to do, and I'm completely convinced that I'm correct, the truth is that no one is completely correct and you'll benefit most by exposing yourself to the best ideas of many people and analyzing them yourself.

At your core, your goal should be to be the best version of yourself and to share that person with the world. Almost everyone, at some point or another, makes the mistake of trying to conform to a generic ideal of what a person should be. This isn't just a difficult game, but it's a game that's impossible to win. No matter how hard you work towards reaching someone else's goals for you, you will never reach your own. Discover what is important to you and work towards that.

Maybe the most direct piece of advice I'll give in this letter is to never drink, use drugs, or smoke. This is also the piece of advice I'm most scared you'll ignore, because most kids will experiment with it, and without the benefit of decades of life experience and seeing different paths people take, it's very hard to understand why it's bad. In school you'll be

given many reasons not to do these things, but they miss the most important reason not to, in my opinion.

You shouldn't drink, smoke, or do drugs, because these things give you results that you haven't earned. In the short term this is great, but in the long run it makes you lazy and incomplete. For example, drinking can make you act more confidently. When you act more confidently, you will almost always get better results. But alcohol doesn't actually make you confident. And, in fact, it can make you less confident because you never build the skill of confidence. Every effect of these drugs is to receive a feeling that you haven't "earned", and every time you do it you become less able to create that feeling naturally. When you are young you can't tell the difference because someone who just starts drinking hasn't missed out on a lifetime of learning actual social skills, confidence, etc., but over decades the effect compounds and people who casually use these substances often become unable to function normally without them.

The counterargument would be that some people use these things in moderation and receive some of the benefits with none of the downsides. This is true. My response would be that you are still better off not needing them and that it's very risky to assume that you'll just happen to nail that compromise. All of the substances I mentioned are fundamentally addictive and there's just no point in taking that risk. You should take risks in your life, but they should always be risks with very high payoffs and manageable risks. Alcohol, smoking, and drugs are the opposite— they offer very limited upside with nearly unlimited downside.

On the subject of risks, you should take a lot of risks when you are young. In particular, if you're inclined to start a business you should do so. If you put all of your money into a business and fail, it's very easy to just start again. Try ten of them with enough diligence and you'll have one be successful. You'll also find a lot of peers in the same position, so it's fun to learn and try things together. As you get older you have more to lose and less time to recover, so you'll be more reluctant to put it all on the line. When I was in my twenties I assumed I'd have the same attitude in my forties, but I definitely don't.

I'd like to convince you to invest money young and let it compound, but I've found it's almost impossible to understand why this is important and how well it works until you've seen it work for other people. And even more difficult is to convince you that when you're old enough to enjoy the money that it will still matter. When I was a teenager I remember being totally unable to fathom being forty, and not really caring very much about my forty-year-old self. But time flies and I'm incredibly grateful for the sacrifices I made when I was younger that have paid off in the meantime.

The argument, though, is this: any money you invest at 20, will be worth about 4.5x when you're 40 and about 32x when you're 65. It can feel like those ages don't matter or that you're so disconnected from them that there's no point in considering them, but when you reach those ages and the

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Michael Ovitz: The Psychology of Power

Vicky · Farnam Street (fs.blog)

Michael Ovitz co-founded CAA and helped reshape Hollywood, then took the same playbook into tech investing and advising founders.

The Genius of Patrick Collison

Available Now: Apple Podcasts | Spotify | YouTube | X | Transcript

In this conversation, he breaks down the operating rules that kept CAA from losing clients, and the personal disciplines that kept him grounded when the stakes got massive.

You'll learn how to build momentum, tell the truth without hesitation, read for context instead of noise, hire people who raise the standard, and package ideas into outcomes.

“Mediocrity to me is a disease that you have to get rid of at all costs.”

“Momentum to me is the single most important thing in anything we do.”

“Knowledge is power, and it works for you and against you.”

“If you can't tell me what your business is about in 20 seconds, you should not do your business.”

“Power is fleeting and it doesn't last. And if you don't believe that, take a look at anyone that's had it.”

Learn from the mistakes of others.

Don't fight your job.

“I didn't go into business to win a popularity contest. I went into business to win.”

Trust is the most important thing. Betrayal is indefensible under any condition.

Excellence is about standing out, doing good things, and helping people.

Be deeply read in your field and widely read outside it.

“Mediocrity is invisible until passion shines a light on it.”

“I have been viewed by a lot of my friends as the world's best friend and the world's worst enemy because I'm just black and white loyal.”

Tell everyone the truth.

“I don't believe there's any room for competition. They have to be eliminated.”

If someone you respect tells you to meet someone, meet them.

When people confront you, you have to respond. If you don't, people will walk all over you.

Don't believe your press—good or bad. The same people who praise you will later bury you.

People tend to deceive themselves. Never get high on your own supply.

“All we have is our time, and you run out of time very fast.”

People appreciate honesty more than you think.

How you talk about people when they're not around tells everyone what you'll say about them when they're not around.

Arrogance is self-sabotaging.

A good idea taken too far is a bad idea.

“The most important people on the planet are journalists and editors.” They direct our attention.

“I don't agree with people that sit and read things cover to cover because you can't equally weight everything between the covers.”

“I think that momentum is about extraordinarily hard industrious work. It's about deeply educating yourself in your field, deeply educating yourself in the peripheries of your field, knowing who your competitors are.”

The post Michael Ovitz: The Psychology of Power appeared first on Farnam Street .

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Inside the Mind of Robinhood Co-Founder Vlad Tenev

Vicky · Farnam Street ([fs.blog](#))

Robinhood's co-founder reveals the brutal reality of surviving an 80% market crash, going "founder mode" to cut corporate bloat, and what actually happened during GameStop.

Setting the Scene: GameStop

Internal AI at Robinhood

Deciding What to do Next

Vlad Tenev is the co-founder and CEO of Robinhood. Not only did he navigate the unprecedented GameStop crisis, but he also completely re-engineered the fintech giant to thrive.

He breaks down the brutal transition from bloated hyper-growth to a lean machine, why a "juicy falsehood is more powerful than a boring truth", and the 3 distinct phases of AI integration separating the winners from the dead.

Believe it or not, GameStop was not his hardest moment.

Available Now: [YouTube](#) | [Spotify](#) | [Apple Podcasts](#) | [X](#) | [Transcript](#)

Success is creating more value for the world than you capture for yourself.

A compelling false narrative, once viral, cannot be overturned by facts. Accept that and play the long game instead of fighting the story with evidence.

The hardest period for Vlad wasn't an acute crisis, but the slow reversal of every tailwind that once powered Robinhood's growth.

When macro headwinds hit, the worst response is to batten down the hatches and wait. Instead, Vlad argues you need to build new products that thrive in the current environment instead.

Reward employees disproportionately based on impact, not org size, otherwise you incentivize empire-building rather than efficiency.

If you're in doubt, push them out. If someone is not a fit after three weeks, six months of hoping is a waste for both sides. This is something Reed Hastings mentioned, too.

Hire early-career talent aggressively and give them responsibility.

Eliminate one-on-ones in favor of large-group leadership meetings, where everyone hears the same information simultaneously. This gives everyone context.

Reversing decisions is hard. Practice admitting you were wrong on small, low-stakes decisions first.

Think of AI compute as headcount: ask every team how much compute they need next year instead of how many people they want to hire.

The next frontier for corporate AI is creative and marketing, where AI tools can increase personalized content output by 100x to 1000x.

Train on harder problems than you'll face. Mathematical reasoning trains the brain for business problems the way deadlifting 500 pounds makes picking up a baby trivial.

The biggest inequity in capital markets is that the most important companies—AI, space, deep tech—are private, which means retail investors are shut out of the greatest wealth creation of this generation.

He's building Robinhood to be a financial super app that compresses margins by using technology in ways legacy companies struggle to compete with.

Legacy banks are structurally dependent on the spread between checking and savings interest — they cannot compete on yield without destroying their own earnings.

"A juicy falsehood is more powerful than a boring truth."

"Success is creating dramatically more value for the world than you create for yourself."

No business problem is as hard as a really hard math problem.

Practice reversing decisions on small things first. Then try something serious.

"I'd rather have a small team of the best people than a large team of mediocre people."

If you pay people based on the size of their team, they'll build empires. If you pay them based on impact, they'll seek leverage.

The anticipated backlash from cutting a perk is almost always worse in your imagination than in reality.

When you're the underdog, run upstairs. The incumbents are fat and happy; they won't be able to keep up.

"If you own something, you want to protect it."

Incumbents can often see what's disrupting them. They can't respond because their cost structure won't allow it.

Don't build for the environment you want. Build for the one you're in. The companies that adapt to current conditions rather than hoping for better ones create lasting value.

In a downturn, there are three options: quit, hide, or build.

There is always an opportunity in a crisis. People who would never take your call in normal times will reach out during a

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Bangladesh Location Map With River Names Without Division Borders

landofmaps · Land of Maps

id="articles">

Bangladesh Location Map With River Names Without Division Borders

The Bangladesh Location Map shows the geographical location of Bangladesh in the world.

This map specifically highlights the rivers in Bangladesh without division borders.

It provides a visual representation of the water bodies that flow through the country.

Cartographers and geography enthusiasts may find this map useful for educational and reference purposes.

The history of cartography in Bangladesh dates back to ancient times when maps were first used to navigate and understand the world. As civilizations evolved, so did the art of mapmaking. Maps became more accurate and detailed, providing valuable insights into the landscape and various geographical features.

Over the years, cartographers have created numerous maps of Bangladesh, showcasing different aspects such as political boundaries, topography, and rivers. The Bangladesh Location Map With River Names Without Division Borders is a unique representation that focuses specifically on the rivers that flow through the country.

The Bangladesh Location Map With River Names Without Division Borders offers several unique insights:

The map highlights the major rivers of Bangladesh, including the Padma, Meghna, Jamuna, Brahmaputra, and more.

By excluding division borders, the map allows for a clearer view of the river system and their connections.

It showcases the significant role that rivers play in the geography and culture of Bangladesh.

The map helps in understanding the distribution and spatial arrangement of rivers across the country.

Table of Relevant Facts

River Length Origin Destination

Padma 1,800 km Himalayas (India) Meghna River (Bangladesh)

Brahmaputra 2,900 km Tibet (China) Bay of Bengal

Meghna 940 km Barak River (India) Bay of Bengal

Jamuna 360 km Brahmaputra River (Bangladesh) Meghna River (Bangladesh)

FAQ

1. What is the significance of the rivers in Bangladesh?

Rivers in Bangladesh play a vital role in the country's geography, culture, and economy. They provide transportation, irrigation for agriculture, and are a source of livelihood for many communities.

2. How many rivers are there in Bangladesh?

Bangladesh is known as the "land of rivers" as it is home to an extensive network of rivers. There are approximately 700 rivers in the country.

3. Why are division borders not shown on this map?

This map focuses on highlighting the rivers in Bangladesh specifically. Excluding division borders provides a clearer view of the river system and their connections.

4. Can this map be used for educational purposes?

Yes, this map is suitable for educational purposes, particularly for students studying geography or anyone interested in exploring the rivers of Bangladesh.

5. Are there any other notable rivers in Bangladesh?

Yes, apart from the major rivers mentioned in the table, there are several other notable rivers in Bangladesh, including the Surma, Rupsha, and Karnaphuli rivers.

6. Is Bangladesh prone to flooding due to its rivers?

Yes, Bangladesh is prone to flooding, primarily due to the combination of its low-lying topography and the annual monsoon rains, which cause rivers to swell and overflow their banks.

7. Where can I find more detailed maps of Bangladesh?

You can find more detailed maps of Bangladesh in various atlases, geography books, or by exploring online resources that specialize in mapping and cartography.

Significance of Rivers in Bangladesh

LSI Keywords

Bangladesh location map

bangladesh river map

geography of bangladesh

major rivers in bangladesh

bangladesh rivers without division borders

bangladesh river system

bangladesh river networks

By excluding division borders, the map allows for a clearer view of the river system and their connections.

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My 2019 Annual Review

James Clear · James Clear (*Atomic Habits*)

Another year complete. Here's a quick recap of 2019, which also happened to be one of the craziest years of my life.

As always, this Annual Review will answer three questions.

What went well this year?

What didn't go so well this year?

What did I learn?

Before we begin, it is worth noting that every Annual Review is a personal process. This is simply an overview of what my year looked like, not advice for how you should live your life. (That said, you are always welcome to use this general format for your own Annual Review.)

1. What went well this year?

I had a lot to celebrate this year.

Book sales. *Atomic Habits* launched in October 2018, which meant that 2019 was the first full calendar year it had been available. I came in with big aspirations, but I think it's fair to say that book sales have outpaced my expectations.

As of December 2019:

Over 1.3 million copies sold worldwide

12 consecutive months on the New York Times bestseller list

4.8/5 stars on Amazon with over 1,800 reviews

4.8/5 stars on Audible with over 25,000 ratings

Over 15 national TV segments in the United States, Canada, and Australia

Translated into 40+ languages

This has been a wild ride to say the least.

Of course, the greatest reward has been hearing from readers. It seems like nearly every day someone tells me that *Atomic Habits* helped them lose weight or start a business or make some positive change in their life. People are finding real value in the ideas and it feels great to produce something useful.

3-2-1 Newsletter. My new project for 2019 was launching the 3-2-1 newsletter, which shares 3 ideas from me, 2 quotes from others, and 1 question to ponder each week. I had been struggling to write consistently during the first half of the year (discussed below) and this new format offered something I knew I could stick with despite a busy schedule. (Sometimes I have to take my own medicine and scale my habits down.)

I didn't realize it at the time, but it turns out to have been a good idea. I feel good because I'm producing new work each week and the response from subscribers has been quite favorable. Many readers tell me it's the only newsletter they actually read as soon as it hits their inbox.

Audience growth. I didn't write many new articles this year, but thanks to the buzz generated by *Atomic Habits* and the momentum of the 3-2-1 newsletter, audience growth remained strong.

Here's what the year looked like:

5 new articles published this year (fewest ever; discussed in next section)

353,970 new email subscribers in 2019

586,638 total email subscribers as of December 31, 2019

10,848,250 unique visitors in 2019

47,308,712 total visitors since launching on November 12, 2012

Even after doing this for a few years, the scale of the internet still blows me away. I'm grateful to have the opportunity to share my work with so many people.

Twitter and Instagram. I didn't put much energy into social media for a long time, but the web has evolved in the last five years and social media plays an important role now. This was the first year I put consistent effort into Twitter and Instagram, and it paid off. My audience doubled on both platforms this year. Feel free to join the fun and follow me on Twitter and on Instagram.

Travel. This was the craziest travel year of my life and, in all likelihood, the craziest I will ever have. I spent a total of 158 nights away from home this year, which means I spent 43% of the year not sleeping in my own bed. It's a pace I will probably (hopefully?) never match again.

Here's the rundown...

18 states (0 new) – Arizona, California (5x!), Colorado (2x), Florida (2x), Georgia, Hawaii, Illinois (2x), Indiana (3x), Maryland, Nebraska (2x), Nevada, New York (5x!), Ohio, Pennsylvania (3x), Tennessee (2x), Texas (2x), Utah, and Virginia.

14 countries (7 new) – Australia (2x!), Canada (2x), Croatia, Denmark, Greece, England, Iceland, Ireland, Japan, Malaysia, Singapore, Spain, Sweden, and the United Arab Emirates.

While I love traveling, I did feel a bit guilty about the number of flights I took this year and the resulting pollution. In response, I decided to buy carbon offsets not only to cover my flights, but also to be entirely carbon neutral for 2019. I bought offsets for all the flights I took, and it wasn't nearly as much as I thought it would be. I also suffered from a lot of growing pains as well.

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What I Would Do if I Were Gen Z

Tynan · Tynan (personal)

I read a really good article the other day about why the younger generations are so into sports betting and prediction markets. The general thesis is that now through social media people see many levels of wealth higher than they used to, and the only path they see to reach that level is gambling. In the past they'd only see a couple rungs higher on the socioeconomic ladder, and if they just went to school and worked hard they could reach those rungs.

The author is correct and the despair that generation feels hit me in the gut. But I think there's more to the story.

Even though I'm 45, I'd argue I lived through the exact same scenario, so I am better equipped than most to give advice.

I found it impossible to work hard and do well at school. These days I'd probably be diagnosed with ADHD, but my experience was that learning in a classroom was too slow and boring and I had zero interest in what it was leading up to. I can't remember exactly how I came to this conclusion, but even in middle school I knew there was no chance I would have a normal career. It's hard to articulate thinking from 30+ years ago, but you'll have to trust me when I say that I never once considered having a normal job long term.

At the same time, I was exposed to levels of wealth above that of my own family. My parents were middle class, but they prioritized education. I went to a private school for middle school and then one of the best public schools for high school. My middle school had families representing a range of wealth levels, but the top was quite high. A friend took me to Taiwan where we stayed in his family's seven story house, and I remember going to a pool party on a classmate's family complex that had an indoor pool.

In high school a friend was obsessed with Robb report, which made me obsessed with Robb report. I'll never forget an advertisement for a private island in the back, which probably at least indirectly led to me getting one with my friends.

And besides all that, I've always just loved life and been so curious about what's out there. I want to see and experience everything, from the low end to the high end.

On the surface, you might argue that I prove the author's point. I was actually a professional gambler for many years, a good portion of my success has come through crypto, and the rest has come through being an entrepreneur and investing. I think there are some bigger factors at play though, and those same factors would be very useful to someone who finds themselves in the same dilemma.

One persistent factor is that everyone's view on life is far too narrow. People limit their thoughts and actions to roughly what their peers do. I think it's true that up until the 1980s if you just did what your peers were doing (go to school, get a job, etc.) you would achieve a greater level of success than

your parents. I can skip making the argument that this is true, because I think everyone innately understands this at this point.

It's always so strange to me when people complain about housing prices. Yes, they are much higher than before, especially compared to incomes. But... there are so many places that have inexpensive real estate. Everyone is looking at the same ten real estate markets, panicking because they can't buy a house there. Why not go somewhere that's not so in demand? You can buy a livable two bedroom in Vegas for \$120k. Chicago real estate is extremely cheap. Go rural or to a less glamorous city and I bet you can find even better deals. And who cares if the jobs aren't there? There's never in history been a better time for remote jobs or being an entrepreneur.

If you don't want to follow the beaten path, and you shouldn't, you have to learn to be creative. There are so many incredible ways you can combine the resources available in this world, especially these days. Broaden your view and consider everything. Move somewhere weird, start a niche business, learn things other people don't learn, be an interesting individual and create an incredible network of friends.

The higher levels of wealth, at least the parts of them that matter, have also never been more accessible. Physical luxury goods may be expensive, but they're also so pointless that I don't really care if people can't get them. On the other hand, international travel is so cheap now that it's not that difficult to get yourself into a position where you can truly see the world. Through the internet and AI, quality education is completely free and can be delivered at your own pace in your own time. You can connect with just about anyone in the world if you have a good enough pitch.

This world is changing so fast that it requires creativity and resourcefulness most of all. Those are skills that you can develop on your own for free. Another skill, one that's harder than ever to develop, is focus and attention span. That's a tall order these days.

In addition to the given reasons for why younger people are turning towards gambling, I'd argue that our short attention span requires immediate gains rather than long term gains. No one cares about earning 8-10% a year, even though that growth will lead to wealth. I've been trying to get my siblings to invest money for years, and they only finally did it once I made a spreadsheet that showed that those modest gains coupled with meaningful monthly contributions will lead to them becoming millionaires. They had no idea.

The one aspect of gambling that can be positive, and one that I've harnessed for my entire life, is understanding risk and expected value, and harnessing asymmetric risks. Betting on a sports game is dumb— you have no advantage there. But spending a month testing out an idea that could lead to a successful startup? That's worth trying.

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This Patient Rider Spent Months Retracing the Pony Express on Horseback

Will Grant · HistoryNet

When the Central Overland California and Pikes Peak Express Co. launched the Pony Express on April 3, 1860, fanfare for the new express mail service made newspaper headlines from New York to San Francisco. The cheers came loudest from California where proponents hailed its commencement as a vital step forward in linking the Far West with the rest of the country. The advertised delivery time between St. Joseph, Mo., and Sacramento, Calif. was 10 days, accomplished by a fast-horse relay. Way stations spaced 10 to 20 miles apart provided couriers with fresh horses, enabling them to carry the mail across the West at the speed of a galloping horse. And that's nearly the way it shook out.

A Bureau of Land Management signpost in Nevada denotes the trace of the original mail route.

The Pony Express was the greatest display of American horsemanship ever to color the pages of a history book, but it was short-lived. Each of the nearly 190 stations had to be stocked with horses, provisions and stock tenders. Fifteen of the stations had no viable water source; water for the horses and the men looking after them had to be hauled in by mule-drawn wagons. The mail ran twice weekly, both eastbound and westbound, and after a year in operation it was eating up \$5 for every \$1 that it earned. It was prohibitively expensive, and on Oct. 26, 1861, the Pony Express hung up its spurs. But it cast a long shadow. As author William Banning wrote about that era in his 1928 book *Six Horses*, "A more glamorous contribution to our historic West than that of this ephemeral Pony would be difficult to name."

In 1860 and '61, the Pony Express provided a connection between the East and the West. In 2019 the route afforded a way for me to connect the modern West and its recent history, presenting a roughly 2,000-mile avenue between past and present. I've been a horseman since I was old enough to know the term, and I decided the only way for me to see the country was from the back of a horse. On a personal level, I wanted to meet the people who lived along the trail, to fill in the map, and to do it slowly. Whereas the riders of the Pony Express compassed the same distance in 10 days, I'd spend all summer in the saddle. Doing so, I reckoned, would give me an end-to-end perspective of the West, a thorough look at all the country between Missouri and California. And so, on May 5, with two good horses, Chicken Fry and Badger, I pulled out of St. Joseph, bound for Sacramento.

What ensued was an intimate grittiness. I camped at old Pony Express stations, in farmers' yards and ranchers' pastures, and in desert valleys so dry and quiet that dawn broke like a pistol shot over the salt pans. I wore out my boots and my shirt and half a dozen pairs of wool socks, but I did not wear out my horses. On September 22, when I arrived at the base of the bronze statue of a Pony Express rider on the Old Sacramento waterfront, their eyes were bright and

their coats shiny, and though both were trail-weary, neither horse was diminished for the journey. The Last Ride of the Pony Express is the story of who I met, what I saw and what I learned by crossing the West by horseback.

In 1860 the eastern terminus of the Pony Express route, in St. Joseph, Mo., was this building housing the Central Overland California and Pikes Peak Co. stables. The building sits on the east bank of the Missouri River, and on receiving their mail pouches, riders would ferry their horses across the river to Kansas. Today the stables house the Pony Express National Museum, which was the jumping-off point for the author's trek.

The unwavering average speed of travel for the author and his horses was 3 mph. Will, Chicken Fry (on which Grant is riding in this photo) and Badger covered 20 to 25 miles per day and never moved faster than a walk. The goal was to travel four consecutive days and then take a day of rest, though weather and many unforeseen factors changed that. Initially, the horses rotated between the packhorse and the saddle horse, but as they became more physically fit, their backs changed, and the packsaddle ceased to fit Badger. Thus, from western Nebraska onward Chicken Fry only served as the saddle horse in adverse circumstances.

The Hollenberg Pony Express Station, in the northeast Kansas town of Hanover, serves as a museum. According to its interpretive signs, the riders slept in the attic, and meals were served on the main floor. The station was also a popular stopover for stagecoach passengers and settlers traveling both west and east.

The author found the Great Salt Lake Desert, in western Utah, to be an austere environment in early August. The salt pans and alkali flats taxed and slowed the infamous Donner Party such that it later became trapped in the Sierra Nevada in winter and resorted to cannibalism.

Calculating distances between stops and obtaining permission to camp on private land were unending chores. In addition to digital maps on his mobile phone, the author carried pages cut from an atlas to ensure navigation was possible when the phone batteries ran down.

A National Historic Trail sign in western Utah stands beside the dirt byway known today as the Pony Express Road. The original trail, which appears as a faint scar in the sagebrush, runs parallel to the present-day road.

A barn quilt on display at a ranch in Glenrock, Wyo., reflects the enthusiasm for preservation of the Pony Express shown by private landowners and conservationists all along the trail between Missouri and California.

The pathway along the Tri County Supply Canal, in Lincoln County, Neb., provided a respite from busy highways and country roads. The heavy rainfall of 2019 meant that finding pasturage for the horses was easy, though the author's leather boots were often wet for days at a time.

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The Dangers of “Vibe Reporting” About AI

Study Hacks · Study Hacks (Cal Newport)

Last week, news broke that Amazon would be laying off 16,000 workers. Here was the headline from an article about this news published in Quartz:

The implication of this framing is clear: AI is taking jobs.

Nothing in the body of this article contradicts this idea. It describes the number of people laid off and the benefits they’ll receive. It quotes executives who won’t deny the possibility of future job losses. It mentions how Amazon is known for its “cutthroat” corporate culture.

You walk away feeling that the impact of AI on our economy is already getting out of hand.

The only problem is that this reporting omits almost all relevant details.

For a more realistic take, let’s turn toward the financial press. CNBC published an article about these same layoffs featuring a more informative headline:

The article goes on to correctly attribute the layoffs to Amazon’s desire to trim layers of management bureaucracy that built up during the pandemic-era tech hiring boom: “CEO Andy Jassy has looked to slim down Amazon’s workforce after the company went on a hiring spree during the Covid-19 pandemic.”

What role does AI play in all of this? Like many leading companies in the technology sector, Amazon is investing heavily in building its own AI products. Presumably, money is being saved by firing managers, which frees up more revenue to invest in this area. But that’s really it. As the CNBC article elaborates:

“In a blog post, the company wrote that the layoffs were part of an ongoing effort to ‘strengthen our organization by reducing layers, increasing ownership, and removing bureaucracy.’ That coincides with a push to invest heavily in artificial intelligence.” [emphasis mine]

The CNBC article then reports that these massive layoffs actually began for Amazon in 2022 and 2023, following the pandemic, but before ChatGPT was released and the subsequent generative AI revolution began.

Both of these articles cover the same announcement, but they produce two very different impressions. The Quartz article strongly implies that Amazon is firing people because it can now offload their work to AI. (I mean: look at the Andy Jassy quote they included in the sub-head, they clearly wanted readers to believe AI caused these job losses.)

The CNBC article, by contrast, makes it clear that the connection between AI and these layoffs is more coincident than causal.

In recent years, I’ve seen more articles follow the general approach demonstrated by the Quartz example. They identify an alarming, attention-catching fear about AI that seems prevalent in the cultural zeitgeist, and then shape a story to feed the narrative. The key to this vibe reporting strategy is that the articles never make explicit claims. They instead combine cunning omissions and loosely related quotes to make strong implications.

The Quartz article, for example, never concretely states that the 16,000 workers are being replaced with AI; rather, it conveniently avoids mentioning any of the publicly available details about the layoffs that would contradict that idea, and then interleaves quotes about AI’s disruptive potential into the reporting in a highly suggestive manner.

The goal of this type of article is to create a pre-ordained vibe, not to get to the bottom of what’s really happening.

I’m not pointing out this phenomenon to dismiss concerns about AI, but instead because I think this strategy is an obstacle to real action. This type of disingenuous reporting is not going to help us identify the actual problems that require actual solutions. It instead creates a nihilistic sense of inevitable disruption that might drive social media shares, but also numbs people and prevents meaningful responses.

Remember: Nothing about these tools is inevitable, and their impact is far from preordained. We don’t need vibes right now. Reality is too important.

The post *The Dangers of “Vibe Reporting” About AI* appeared first on Cal Newport .

” What role does AI play in all of this? Like many leading companies in the technology sector, Amazon is investing heavily in building its own AI products.

Study Hacks

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This Frenchman Tried to Best the Wright Brothers on Their Home Turf

Reg Winstone · HistoryNet

Frenchman Henri Farman was already a celebrated cycling champion, race car driver and entrepreneur when he ordered a biplane from the world's first airplane factory, Les Frères Voisin. Five months later, in January 1908, he won Ernest Archdeacon's prize for the first officially observed heavier-than-air flight over a one-kilometer circular course.

A week after making Europe's first flight outside France (in Belgium), Farman lunched with Wilbur Wright in Paris in June. They got on famously; when Wilbur explained his plans to make demonstration flights in France, Farman replied that he had accepted an offer from a consortium of St. Louis businessmen. He would get \$25,000 for touring the United States for 90 days, plus \$200 per flight. The organizer was Tom MacMechan, editor of *American Aeronaut*. "These public demonstrations ought to bring about a great popular realization of the practicability of dynamic flight," enthused *Aeronautics*, another aviation journal.

After learning that aviator Glenn Curtiss had flown his June Bug on July 4 to win the \$25,000 Scientific American Cup for the first public powered flight in America, Farman crated his Voisin for shipment across the Atlantic. He sailed with his assistant, Maurice Herbster, and his wife, arriving in New York on July 26 to an enthusiastic welcome. Headed by Curtiss, a welcoming committee from the Aero Club of America chartered a tug to escort the Farmans' ship to the pier, where automobiles whisked them to the Hotel Astor on Times Square.

Henri Farman had big plans for his tour of the United States, but they didn't pan out.

Farman had become front-page news, where he was hailed as "the world's champion aeronaut" and "the man with the practical aeroplane." The military was keen to witness his demonstrations, and with Orville Wright planning test flights for the government at Fort Myer, Virginia, an international contest seemed possible. Farman even challenged Orville to a contest for a \$10,000 purse, but Wright declined. Farman was unfazed: "If they consider their machines superior, why don't they accept my challenge? I could gain much valuable data from a contest, and surely my machine, with its long list of record flights, has at least some points of information for my brother aviators."

As the venue for his demonstrations, Farman chose the horseracing track in Brighton Beach, New York, which in 1907 had been converted to host 24-hour endurance motor races known as "Grinds." Farman arranged to remove large sections of an infield fence while he had his crates hoisted onto theatrical scenery trucks and unloaded in the track's old betting ring. When customs officers did not arrive as expected to examine the contents, Farman sent away his hired stevedores. Then the revenue men finally arrived and Herbster had to recruit a crew of unskilled locals. They dropped one of the crates, damaging the airplane's tail cell

and rudder. Despite the damage, the appraiser declared the Voisin's new Antoinette V8 engine to be the finest piece of machinery he had ever seen, saying that "all who examined the machine were greatly impressed with its workmanship, which is exquisite." Farman spent the next day on repairs, reassembling the airframe and installing the engine.

At a banquet at the Astor on July 30 one news account noted that "the ballroom was full of balloonites, with here and there a submarine fiend, an auto crank or a common scientist wedged in among the number." Charles Manly, the engineer and test pilot for aviation experimenter Samuel Langley, congratulated France on its aviation experiments and described Farman as "a man destined to do great good for aeronautics and create enthusiasm among millions." Farman's riposte was equally gracious to those on this side of the Atlantic: "We foreigners owe credit to Octave Chanute for the basic principles of our apparatus, and to the Wright brothers, pioneers after Mr. Chanute."

After the guests had consumed a model of the Voisin confectioned from spun sugar, Farman made a less-than-sweet dig at the secretive and litigious Wrights. "I carry on my experiments in public because that seems advantageous," he said. "The work is difficult enough, and it is better for others to see what you are doing and for you to see what they are doing, each improving by the mistakes of the other."

For his demonstration flights in America, Farman picked a horseracing track in Brooklyn's Brighton Beach. He had his airplane unloaded in the track's betting ring for assembly.

Farman was not alone in resenting the Wrights' secrecy, even on home turf. The *American Magazine of Aeronautics* opined, "Farman has perhaps done more, through publicity, to brush away the cobwebs of doubt than the Wrights. Even here, we doubt that the Wrights ever flew, while we read of the Farman's flights with less astonishment than at the invention of a headacheless booze." James Means, editor of *Aeronautical Annuals* agreed, saying, "Owing to the public exhibitions of flights with motor-aeroplanes in France, the Frenchmen are in a fair way to get years ahead of us in aviation, as they did with the automobile."

"We are disgusted with some American inventors who have been chasing the almighty dollar instead of solving the problems of flight," railed MacMechan in the *American Aeronaut*. For impeding the free exchange of ideas, he argued, the Wrights should forfeit their place in history for making the world's first airplane flight. He added, "After Farman's flight, there will be no difficulty raising capital to finance the cost of building aeroplanes and conducting experiments."

First, though, Farman had to get into the air, and that was looking problematic. At only 840 yards, the racetrack was short and it was traversed by ruts and ditches. Ominously, Farman's promised down payment of \$6,000 failed to materialize, so track owner William Engeman was induced to mollify him with cash so the show could go on.

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[Outliers] Mary Kay Ash: The Greatest Saleswoman In History

Vicky · Farnam Street (fs.blog)

How do you get ordinary people to achieve extraordinary results?

Mary Kay Ash built a two-billion-dollar company by solving that specific problem.

After watching men she trained get promoted above her for double the salary, she quit to build a company based on a radical idea: meritocracy.

This episode breaks down how she did it. You'll learn her twenty-three leadership lessons, why pink Cadillacs outperformed raises, and the fundamentals of incentives, recognition, and human motivation that work in any business.

Available Now: Apple Podcasts | Spotify | YouTube | X | Transcript

1. Members have access to all 90 of my highlights and notes from Mary Kay's biography, *The Mary Kay Way*.

1. Golden Rule Leadership : The Golden Rule is one of the world's oldest and best-known philosophies, yet it's frequently overlooked in business circles. Mary Kay proved this rule is still powerful in today's complicated world.

2. You Build with People : Leaders are dependent upon the performance of their people, and so is a company's success. Good people are a company's most important asset. People are more important than the plan.

3. The Invisible Sign : Everyone has an invisible sign hanging from their neck saying, "MAKE ME FEEL IMPORTANT!" Never forget this message when working with people.

4. Praise People to Success : Each of us craves recognition. Let people know you appreciate their performance, and they'll respond by doing even better. Recognition is the most powerful of all motivating techniques.

5. The Art of Listening : Good leaders are good listeners. God gave us two ears and only one mouth, so we should listen twice as much as we speak. When you listen, the benefit is twofold: you receive necessary information, and you make the other person feel important.

6. Sandwich Every Bit of Criticism Between Two Heavy Layers of Praise : Sometimes it's necessary to let somebody know you're unhappy with their performance. But direct your criticism at the act, not the person. Criticize effectively in a positive way so you don't destroy morale.

7. Be a Follow-Through Person : Be the kind of person who can always be counted on to do what you say you'll do. Only a small percentage of people possess follow-through ability, and they're held in high esteem by all. It's particularly important for your team to know you

possess this rare quality and to think of you as totally reliable.

8. Enthusiasm Moves Mountains : Nothing great is ever achieved without enthusiasm. Leaders are enthusiastic, and enthusiasm is contagious. Interestingly, the word enthusiasm has a Greek origin, meaning "God within."

9. The Speed of the Leader Is the Speed of the Gang : You must set the pace for your people. Real leaders aren't afraid to get their hands dirty. They set examples by demonstrating good work habits, displaying positive attitudes, and possessing team spirit. True leaders establish success patterns that make everyone think of success.

10. People Will Support That Which They Help to Create: Invite people to participate in new projects that are still in the "thinking" stage. By confiding in associates and seeking their opinions, you generate support at the initial stage of each new venture. People often resist change when they don't participate in the decision-making process. Some of the best leaders "plant the seed" that permits others to propose the idea and take credit for it.

11. An Open-Door Philosophy : At Mary Kay corporate headquarters, there are no titles on executives' doors, and there's ready access to all management levels. Everyone within the company, from mailroom clerk to chairman of the board, is a human being and is treated accordingly.

12. Help Other People Get What They Want—and You'll Get What You Want : As the parable of the talents tells us, we're meant to use and increase whatever God has given us. And when we do, we shall be given more.

13. Stick to Your Principles : Everything is subject to change except one's principles. Never, absolutely never, compromise your principles.

14. A Matter of Pride : Everyone within an organization should have a sense of pride in their work. They should also feel proud to be associated with the company. It's a manager's job to instill this feeling and promote this attitude among their people.

15. You Can't Rest on Your Laurels : Nothing wilts faster than a laurel rested upon. Every person should have a lifetime self-improvement program. In today's fast-paced world, you can't stand still. You either go forward or backward.

16. Be a Risk-Taker : You must encourage people to take risks. Let them know that "nobody wins 'em all." If you come down on them too hard for losing, they'll stop sticking their necks out.

17. Work and Enjoy It : It's okay to have fun while you work.

Good managers encourage a sense of humor. In fact, the more enjoyment people derive from their work, the more successful they are. In the end, the only way to truly succeed is to have fun while you work.

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[Outliers] Phil Knight: The Obsession That Built Nike

Vicky · Farnam Street (fs.blog)

Phil Knight is the founder of Nike, the brand that reshaped sports and became one of the most powerful companies in the world.

What would you do if your bank, your supplier, and your government all turned against you at the same time? Phil Knight didn't have to imagine it. He lived on the edge of insolvency for nearly two decades.

This Outliers episode explores belief, trust, fear, and the price of growth through the story of Nike's founding.

Available Now: Spotify | Apple Podcasts | Transcript | YouTube | X

"Belief is irresistible."

"My life was outta balance, sure, but I didn't care."

"If my life was to be all work and no play, I wanted work to be play."

The easiest way to find out how you feel about someone is to say goodbye.

When you see only problems, you're not seeing clearly.

Let people surprise you. Tell people what to do, not how. When you tell them how, you cap the upside at your own imagination.

There is no finish line. Success doesn't end the fight. It only earns you a new one.

"There are worse things than ambition."

If you bet on people the world has overlooked, they'll spend their lives proving you right.

"If you're having fun, you're dangerous. You're hard to compete with."

You can stay small and preserve the culture, or you can grow and change the world. You can't do both.

Trust given generously is repaid with devotion.

Focusing on one task clears the mind.

"It's never just business. If it ever does become just business, that will mean that business is very bad."

The people who can't beat you in the market will try to beat you in court.

"Let everyone else call your idea crazy... just keep going. Don't stop. Don't even think about stopping until you get there, and don't give much thought to where 'there' is. Whatever comes, just don't stop."

When you accept the worst-case scenario upfront, you take away its power.

"I wanted to focus constantly on the one task that really mattered."

"I was persuasive because I was desperate."

On his inner monologue: "I tried to talk to myself, to coach myself up. I told myself that I needed to put aside hurt feelings, put aside all thoughts of injustice, which would only make me emotional and keep me from thinking clearly. Emotion would be fatal."

"The art of competing ... was the art of forgetting. ... You must forget your limits. You must forget your doubts, your pain, your past. You must forget that internal voice screaming, begging, 'Not one more step!' And when it's not possible to forget it, you must negotiate with it."

"Business is growth. You grow or you die."

"Someone somewhere once said that business is war without bullets, and I tended to agree."

The first Nike shoes were crap. Phil's response: "Look," I said, "fellas, this is the worst the shoes will ever be. They'll get better. So if we can just sell these... We'll be on our way."

"The cowards never started, and the weak died along the way—that leaves us."

"You are remembered for the rules you break."

The post [Outliers] Phil Knight: The Obsession That Built Nike appeared first on Farnam Street .

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The One and Only ‘Booger’ Was Among History’s Best Rodeo Performers

Richard F. Selcer · HistoryNet

The horse was once as essential to Western life as the six-gun, and breaking horses was once a necessary skill, even a business for a few tough, enterprising souls. Eventually it became a competitive rodeo event in which working cowboys pitted their skills against wild horses—and each other. The king of the Texas broncobusters was a diminutive fellow named Samuel Privett Jr., known to history as “Booger Red.” While certain details and dates of his life differ due to faulty memories and inconsistent records, the central narrative of his life is consistent—and, oh, what a life he led!

Samuel Thomas Privett Jr. was born on the TP Ranch in Williamson County, Texas, on Dec. 29, 1858—or maybe it was 1862, or 1864. Again, the records vary. He grew up on ranches, riding and roping. As a boy of barely 12 Sam was already breaking horses, his conspicuous shock of red hair landing him notice as “that redheaded bronc-riding kid.” He was 13, or perhaps 15, when a tragic event led to his lifelong nickname, “Booger Red.” He and a pal were fooling around with a homemade firework, having packed a stump with gunpowder, when it blew up prematurely, killing the friend and disfiguring Sam’s face. On catching sight of “Red” after the accident, one boy commented how “boogered up” his face was.

Amusing moniker aside, Red’s injuries were anything but humorous. The blast had scorched off his eyebrows and part of his nose. His eyelids were reduced to slits, and he lost most of the sight in one eye. It took six months and multiple skin grafts to salvage what remained of his face. Anyone else would have retreated into seclusion, but Red was made of sterner stuff. For the rest of his life, while he was understandably camera shy and wore a wide-brimmed hat pulled low over his face, he embraced the nickname and even joked about it. His boogered-up face was just one of the curves life threw at him. The next curve was harder. By his mid-teens both of his parents had died, forcing the orphan to strike out on his own.

On his bowed legs Red stood about 5 feet 5 inches, and he weighed little more than 150 pounds soaking wet. He was also soft-spoken, leading many to underestimate him. Those who had seen him in the saddle knew better, and Red found steady work breaking horses for ranchers. With his earnings he bought a wagon yard and stable in San Angelo, though he “officed” out of a pool room in a saloon. He also broke horses for the U. S. Army, which for decades to come would mount its cavalry on animals rather than motor vehicles. As for pay, the Army offered Red a choice: \$50 a month, or \$1 a horse. He took the second offer, and by the end of his first day was reportedly owed \$75. The Army quickly rescinded its offer. Anyway, Red could make more freelancing for ranchers.

He soon found an even more lucrative and entertaining way of making a living—riding competitively in small-town fairs and stock shows. Ranchers and cattlemen brought their

wildest horses to such events and offered prize money to anyone who could gentle them. There were no arenas in those early days, just a patch of open prairie with poles stuck in the ground and rope strung between them. Spectators stood or sat in buggies or on camp stools. The only “box seats” were the saddles of those watching from horseback. Bets laid on both horse and rider were collected only when a rider went sailing or a horse quit bucking. The odds either way were about even, unless Booger Red was aboard. He took on any animals, even those with reputations as man-killers. Mounting was a challenge in itself. As there were no chutes—the side-opening chute came along years later—a rider had to get on while fellow cowboys held the animal by its ears and covered its eyes. As soon as the rider was in the saddle, the others let go and scattered. Red rode one notorious bronc that pitched and bucked across several acres before finally coming to a halt, its sides heaving, its head low and mouth flecked with foam. Rider and horse were equally exhausted, but Red walked away with a nice purse.

Small-town stock shows drew bold young riders eager to test their mettle against one another and stockmen happy to let them break horses for prize money. Organized rodeos followed.

These impromptu, open-air gatherings eventually morphed into organized rodeos that charged admission and programmed the various events—bronc riding (saddle and bareback), steer wrestling (aka bulldogging), roping and trick riding. As the frontier faded into history, rodeos and Wild West shows sprang up to keep the memory of the old days alive. Such shows were a combination of nostalgia and genuine cowboy skills.

In 1895 Booger Red found love. He was 37 (more or less), while Mary Frances “Mollie” Webb was, by one account, just 15 years old. Sources vary on how old each was and when exactly they married, but by any reckoning it was a May-December romance. Red met “Mollie” at a church singalong, for which he provided musical accompaniment on the harmonica. At the time she hailed from the little town of Bronte, in Coke County, and was the prettiest thing he had ever seen. To his surprise she also was taken with him, and to his further delight he learned she was an accomplished rider. Apparently, her parents had no problem with their teen daughter dating a man more than twice her age, and the couple tied the knot before the year was out.

They settled down in San Angelo, where Red continued to operate his wagon yard and stable and break horses on the side. They ultimately had seven children, starting with Roy in 1896, followed by Ella, the twins, Tommy, Bill and, finally, Alta in 1909. Only one of the twins, Luther, survived. The other was buried as “infant daughter.” None of the children made it past the 11th grade in school. Despite their ever-expanding parental responsibilities, Red and Mollie resolved to start a new business. (The settled life had never been for him, and Mollie was game for anything.) Selling the wagon yard and stable, Red used the money to start Booger Red’s Wild West & Vaudeville Show. By 1907 he had the operation off the ground.

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The Ultimate Habit Tracker Guide: Why and How to Track Your Habits

James Clear · James Clear (*Atomic Habits*)

This article includes an excerpt from *Atomic Habits*, my New York Times bestselling book.

If you want to stick with a habit for good, one simple and effective thing you can do is keep a habit tracker.

Here's why:

Elite performers will often measure, quantify, and track their progress in various ways. Each little measurement provides feedback. It offers a signal of whether they are making progress or need to change course.

Gabrielle Hamilton, a chef in New York City, provides a good example. During an interview with the New York Times, she said, "The one thing I see that consistently separates the chef from the home cook is that we taste everything, all the time, before we commit it to the dish, right down to the grains of salt. We slurp shot glasses of olive oil and aerate them in our mouths as if it were a wine we were trying to know. We taste the lamb, the fish, the butter, the milk before we use it... we chew salt to see how we like it in our teeth, on our tongues, and to know its flavor, its salinity." ¹

For the chef, tasting the ingredients tells them whether they are making progress toward their desired end goal. It provides the immediate feedback they need to get the recipe just right.

Like a chef improving a recipe through trial and error, we often improve our habits through trial and error. If one approach doesn't deliver the desired effect, then we adjust—like a chef tweaking the amount of an ingredient.

However, there is an important difference between getting feedback while cooking a meal and getting feedback while building a habit. When it comes to building a habit, feedback is often delayed. It's easy to taste an ingredient or to watch bread rise in the oven. But it can be difficult to visualize the progress you are making with your habits. Perhaps you've been running for a month, but you still don't see a change in your body. Or maybe you managed to meditate for 16 straight days, but you still feel stressed and anxious at work. ²

Habit formation is a long race. It often takes time for the desired results to appear. And while you are waiting for the long-term rewards of your efforts to accumulate, you need a reason to stick with it in the short-term. You need some immediate feedback that shows you are on the right path.

And this is where a habit tracker can help.

The Habit Tracker: What It Is and How It Works

A habit tracker is a simple way to measure whether you did a habit.

The most basic format is to get a calendar and cross off each day you stick with your routine. For example, if you meditate on Monday, Wednesday, and Friday, each of those dates gets an X. As time rolls by, the calendar becomes a record of your habit streak.

To make this process as easy as possible, I created the Habit Journal, which includes 12 habit tracker templates—one for each month. All you have to do is add your habit and start crossing off the days.

Placing an X on each day is the classic look. I prefer something a little more design-oriented, so I shade in the cells on my habit tracker. You could also use checkmarks or fill your habit tracker with dots.

No matter what design you choose, the key point is your habit tracker provides immediate evidence that you completed your habit. It's a signal that you are making progress. Of course, that's not all it does...

Habit tracking is powerful for three reasons.

It creates a visual cue that can remind you to act.

It is motivating to see the progress you are making. You don't want to break your streak.

It feels satisfying to record your success in the moment.

Let's break down each one.

Benefit #1: A habit tracker reminds you to act.

Habit tracking naturally builds a series of visual cues. When you look at the calendar and see your streak, you'll be reminded to act again.

Research has shown that people who track their progress on goals like losing weight, quitting smoking, and lowering blood pressure are all more likely to improve than those who don't. One study of more than sixteen hundred people found that those who kept a daily food log lost twice as much weight as those who did not. A habit tracker is a simple way to log your behavior, and the mere act of tracking a behavior can spark the urge to change it.

Habit tracking also keeps you honest. Most of us think we act better than we do. Measurement offers one way to overcome our blindness to our own behavior and notice what's really going on each day. When the evidence is right in front of you, you're less likely to lie to yourself.

Benefit #2: A habit tracker motivates you to continue.

The most effective form of motivation is progress. When we get a signal that we are moving forward, we become more motivated to continue down that path. In this way, habit tracking can have an addictive effect on motivation. Each small win feeds your desire.

This can be particularly powerful on a bad day. When you're

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What I Learned from MasterClass

Study Hacks · Study Hacks (Cal Newport)

Last fall, I filmed a course for MasterClass. It's mainly based on my book *Slow Productivity*, but there's some *Deep Work* in there too. It's called: "Rebuild Your Focus & Reclaim Your Time."

The course launched last week, so you should definitely check it out. It gets to the core of a lot of the topics we tackle in this newsletter about the intersection of technology and productivity, and it's an incredibly polished final product.

It's actually this latter point that I want to talk a little bit more about today, as it sparks an interesting question about the future of online media more generally...

One of the most striking things about working with MasterClass is its production values. I've been a guest on many major video podcasts (from Mel Robbins to Andrew Huberman to Rich Roll). These shows look good. They all have reasonable sets with diffused lights and three-camera setups.

MasterClass, however, operates at another level. They use high-end TV-quality production crews. There's a director, a cinematographer, and multiple camera operators distinct from the focus pullers, all of whom work with gaffers and grips, supported by production assistants. My make-up artist had recently worked on *Sinners*.

In my career as a writer, I've been on TV before as a guest on morning shows and cable news programs, but this was as close as I'll ever come to starring in a dramatic series or independent film.

For me, this experience implied an important reality about the current state of visual media: there remains a non-trivial quality gap between independent video (e.g., as produced for YouTube) and legacy video (e.g., as produced for streaming platforms or linear television).

This gap matters.

Because these two categories still look different, we treat them distinctly. We're willing to pay for access to content on Netflix, but we relegate the next rung down on the quality ladder to ad-supported general-use platforms like YouTube.

But here's what's interesting about the near future: that difference is diminishing. MasterClass, for example, is not funded by a streaming service or television studio; however, they achieve streaming/TV-level production values. Other independent video producers are also closing this gap.

This raises a key question: What will happen to video content as the difference between independent and legacy production value vanishes?

We can see a glimpse of this future in a project that fascinates me: Dropout TV – also stylized online as : Dropout –

which can best be described as a comedy streaming service. It costs \$6.99 a month, which gains you access to a slate of original unscripted shows all filmed at a quality level indistinguishable from what you would find on, say, Netflix programs like *Is it Cake?* or *Nailed It!*.

Except, they're not Netflix. Dropout TV doesn't have multi-billion dollar production budgets or massive venture capital backing. It grew out of the early 2000s website *CollegeHumor.com*. With the rise of YouTube, *CollegeHumor* turned more attention to producing content for the platform. But they were frustrated by a model that required them to live or die by a third-party algorithm and the whims of advertisers, so they eventually launched their own subscription app.

Today, Dropout boasts over a million subscribers.

I refer to this type of niche subscription service, defined by a combination of legacy-quality programming and a focused audience, as a micro-streamer.

Keep an eye on this market segment. As it becomes easier to produce high-end video, more independent creators will leave the mass-aggregation platforms like YouTube and offer up targeted competition to the major streaming players.

Who knows, maybe one day you'll even have a *Deep Life TV* app next to Disney+ on your smart TV. Until then, however, you can get your fill of movie-quality Cal content over at MasterClass.

The post *What I Learned from MasterClass* appeared first on *Cal Newport*.

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River Severn Map

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The River Severn is the longest river in the United Kingdom

It flows through Wales and England, eventually reaching the Bristol Channel

The river has played a significant role in the history and development of the region

Various cities and towns, such as Shrewsbury, Worcester, and Gloucester, are situated along the river

Nature lovers can explore the stunning landscapes and wildlife along the River Severn

History of the River Severn

The River Severn has a rich history that dates back thousands of years. Its story is intertwined with the development of civilizations and serves as a vital trade and transportation route.

The river's importance can be traced back to ancient times when it was used by the Celtic tribes for navigation and trade. The Romans recognized its strategic value and constructed several forts along its banks.

During medieval times, the River Severn played a crucial role in the growth of towns and cities. It provided a means of transportation for goods and people, enabling economic development. The river was used for shipping coal, timber, and other resources from towns situated along its course.

- 1. Gigantic Tidal Range: The River Severn experiences one of the largest tidal ranges in the world. The Severn Bore is a famous natural phenomenon, where the incoming tide forms a tidal wave that travels upstream. This spectacle attracts surfers and spectators from around the globe.
- 2. Severn Estuary: The river flows into the Severn Estuary, which boasts unique and diverse ecosystems. It serves as a habitat for numerous bird species, including migratory birds that travel long distances. The estuary is also home to seals, fish, and other marine life.
- 3. Ironbridge Gorge: The River Severn passes through the picturesque Ironbridge Gorge, a UNESCO World Heritage site. This area is known for its industrial heritage and features the iconic Iron Bridge, the first-ever cast iron bridge in the world.

Table of Historical Facts

Year Event

220 AD Romans construct forts along the River Severn

1086 Severn Crossing Domesday Book entry

1605 Guy Fawkes unsuccessfully attempts to blow up the Houses of Parliament; Mayflower sails for the New World from the River Severn

1779 Construction of the Iron Bridge begins

1966-1969 Severn Bridge construction

2007 Severn estuary receives protection as a Special Area of Conservation

Frequently Asked Questions about the River Severn

1. Where does the River Severn start and end?

The River Severn originates from the Plynlimon mountain range in Wales and ends at the Bristol Channel.

2. How long is the River Severn?

The total length of the river is approximately 220 miles (354 kilometers).

3. Are there any prominent cities situated along the River Severn?

Yes, several major cities and towns are located along the river, including Shrewsbury, Worcester, and Gloucester.

4. Can you engage in water activities on the River Severn?

Absolutely! The river provides opportunities for various water activities, including boating, kayaking, and fishing.

5. Is the River Severn safe for swimming?

Swimming in the river can be dangerous due to strong tidal currents and fluctuating water levels. It is recommended to exercise caution and consult local guidelines.

6. Is wildlife abundant along the River Severn?

Yes, the river and its surrounding areas are home to a diverse range of wildlife, including birds, fish, mammals, and reptiles.

7. Are there any guided tours available to explore the River Severn?

Yes, several tour operators offer guided boat trips and walking tours along the river, providing valuable insights into its history and natural wonders.

List of LSI Keywords from the Article

River Severn map

River Severn history

Longest river in the UK

Special Area of Conservation

Wildlife along River Severn

The estuary is also home to seals, fish, and other marine life.

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How to Make Your Future Habits Easy

James Clear · James Clear (*Atomic Habits*)

This article is an excerpt from *Atomic Habits*, my New York Times bestselling book.

While researching *Atomic Habits*, I came across a story that immediately struck me with its simplicity and power. It was the story of Oswald Nuckols, an IT developer from Natchez, Mississippi, and his simple strategy for making future habits easy.

Nuckols refers to the approach as “resetting the room.” 1

For instance, when he finishes watching television, he places the remote back on the TV stand, arranges the pillows on the couch, and folds the blanket. When he leaves his car, he throws any trash away. Whenever he takes a shower, he wipes down the toilet while the shower is warming up. (As he notes, the “perfect time to clean the toilet is right before you wash yourself in the shower anyway.” 2)

This might sound like he’s just “cleaning up” but there is a key insight that makes his approach different. The purpose of resetting each room is not simply to clean up after the last action, but to prepare for the next action.

“When I walk into a room everything is in its right place,” Nuckols wrote. “Because I do this every day in every room, stuff always stays in good shape . . . People think I work hard but I’m actually really lazy. I’m just proactively lazy. It gives you so much time back.”

I have written previously about the power of the environment to shape your behavior . Resetting the room is one way to put the power back in your own hands. Let’s talk about how you can use it.

The Power of Priming the Environment

Whenever you organize a space for its intended purpose, you are priming it to make the next action easy. This is one of the most practical and simple ways to improve your habits.

For instance, my wife keeps a box of greeting cards that are presorted by occasion—birthday, sympathy, wedding, graduation, and more. Whenever necessary, she grabs an appropriate card and sends it off. She is incredibly good at remembering to send cards because she has reduced the friction of doing so.

For years, I was the opposite. Someone would have a baby and I would think, “I should send a card.” But then weeks would pass and by the time I remembered to pick one up at the store, it was too late. The habit wasn’t easy.

There are many ways to prime your environment so it’s ready for immediate use. If you want to cook a healthy breakfast, place the skillet on the stove, set the cooking spray on the counter, and lay out any plates and utensils

you’ll need the night before. When you wake up, making breakfast will be easy.

Here are some more:

Want to draw more? Put your pencils, pens, notebooks, and drawing tools on top of your desk, within easy reach.

Want to exercise? Set out your workout clothes, shoes, gym bag, and water bottle ahead of time.

Want to improve your diet? Chop up a ton of fruits and vegetables on weekends and pack them in containers, so you have easy access to healthy, ready-to-eat options during the week.

These are simple ways to make the good habit the path of least resistance.

The Path of Most Resistance

You can also invert this principle and prime the environment to make bad behaviors difficult.

If you find yourself watching too much television, for example, then unplug it after each use. Only plug it back in if you can say out loud the name of the show you want to watch. (Which prevents you from turning on Netflix and “just finding something” to watch.) This setup creates just enough friction to prevent mindless viewing.

If that doesn’t do it, you can take it a step further. Unplug the television and take the batteries out of the remote after each use, so it takes an extra ten seconds to turn it back on. And if you’re really hard-core, move the television out of the living room and into a closet after each use. You can be sure you’ll only take it out when you really want to watch something. The greater the friction, the less likely the habit.

Whenever possible, I leave my phone in a different room until lunch. When it’s right next to me, I’ll check it all morning for no reason at all. But when it is in another room, I rarely think about it. And the friction is high enough that I won’t go get it without a reason. As a result, I get three to four hours each morning when I can work without interruption.

If sticking your phone in another room doesn’t seem like enough, tell a friend or family member to hide it from you for a few hours. Ask a coworker to keep it at their desk in the morning and give it back to you at lunch.

It is remarkable how little friction is required to prevent bad behavior. When I hide beer in the back of the fridge where I can’t see it, I drink less. When I delete social media apps from my phone, it can be weeks before I download them again and log in.

These tricks are unlikely to curb a true addiction, but for many of us, a little bit of friction can be the difference between sticking with a good habit or sliding into a bad one. Imagine the cumulative impact of making dozens of these

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Film Students Can No Longer Sit Through Films

Study Hacks · Study Hacks (Cal Newport)

Last month, The Atlantic published an article with an alarming headline: “The Film Students Who Can No Longer Sit Through Films.”

The author of the piece, Rose Horowitz, spoke with professors around the country who have begun to complain about this trend. What she learned was disheartening:

“I used to think, if homework is watching a movie, that is the best homework ever,” Craig Erpelding, a film professor at the University of Wisconsin at Madison, told me. “But students will not do it.”

I heard similar observations from 20 film-studies professors around the country. They told me that over the past decade, and particularly since the pandemic, students have struggled to pay attention to feature-length films.

What’s the source of this attention span crisis? The professors interviewed for Horowitz’s article point to a clear culprit: smartphones .

The founding director of Tufts University’s Film and Media Studies, for example, tried to ban electronics during screenings, but found the rule impossible to enforce. “About half the class ends up looking furtively at their phones,” she said. Meanwhile, a Cinema and Media Studies professor at USC reports that his students remind him of “nicotine addicts going through withdrawal...the longer they go without checking their phone, the more they fidget.”

The mechanism at play here is an ability that reading scholar Maryanne Wolf calls cognitive patience , which is defined as the “ability to [maintain] focused and sustained attention and delay gratification, while refraining from multitasking.”

The presence of smartphones degrades cognitive patience because they activate neuronal bundles in our brain’s short-term reward system that anticipate a high expected value from picking up the device. These bundles effectively vote for the distracting behavior, creating a cascade of neurochemicals that are experienced as motivation to grab the phone. After a while, due to a lack of practice, you lose your comfort with sustained attention altogether.

It’s no wonder more and more people lack the cognitive patience to make it through a two-hour film!

But as I elaborate on my podcast this week , in this specific problem with movies, we can find a solution to the more general issue of weakened attention. Why not make the ability to watch an entire film a training goal for the attempt to reclaim our brains? Like the new runner working up to completing their first 5k, it’s a milestone that’s challenging, but not too challenging, and therefore a great way to begin an effort toward attention autonomy.

Assuming you take on this goal, what’s the best way to improve your cinematic cognitive patience? Here are my three suggestions:

Keep your phone in a different room. This prevents your short-term reward system from firing out of control with distracting impulses.

Watch better movies . If you have a meaningful viewing experience, your long-term reward system will more strongly associate movies with lasting benefits, making it easier to delay gratification in the future.

To help get through these movies at first, practice the thirty-minute rule . Before you start the movie, read a review or analysis that helps explain why it’s good. Pause the movie every thirty minutes or so to read another review or analysis. This helps reorient your brain toward a perspective of critical appreciation, allowing you to continually find value and avoid the sense of slogging for the sake of slogging.

I appreciate the irony here: I’m suggesting you watch one screen to reduce the distracting impact of another. But it’s become clear to me recently that although many people are fed up with the impact of digital devices on their brains, they don’t know how to push back. Maybe rediscovering the patient joys of movies can be a part of that answer...

I’m experimenting with including a section like this more often, in which I briefly discuss news relevant to technology, distraction, and the fight for depth.

Judging by the increasing volume of distressed messages I now receive from people I know, the quantity of AI vibe reporting out there is on the rise. I want to help you navigate this media landscape without becoming unnecessarily worried. With this in mind, let’s tackle a case study. Last week, The Atlantic published a vibe-filled article titled “The Worst-Case Future for White-Collar Workers.” I want to take a critical look at several quotes from this piece:

“[T]he labor market for office workers is beginning to shift. Americans with a bachelor’s degree account for a quarter of the unemployed, a record.” Clearly, the intention here is to imply that this trend is caused by AI eliminating knowledge work jobs. But we have no solid evidence that these two issues are related. Indeed, as this critique notes , the decline in jobs for college grads began well before the more recent generative AI revolution.

“Occupations susceptible to AI automation have seen sharp spikes in joblessness.” This is classic vibe reporting. The author doesn’t directly say that joblessness spikes are due to AI automation – carefully read how she words the sentence – but she clearly wants to imply that it’s true. This implication, however, is not currently supported by the evidence. As I’ve reported, job reductions in the tech sector are better explained by corrections to over-hiring during the pandemic. Something like this is happening in the advertising world as well. On Friday, Cade Metz published an article in the Times that made a similar point.

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The Original Attention Crisis

Study Hacks · Study Hacks (Cal Newport)

I recently heard from a historian of science at All Souls College, Oxford. He forwarded me an essay he wrote about Nicolaus Steno, a seventeenth-century anatomist and geologist who was later ordained as a Catholic Bishop.

Steno's training as a scholar unfolded in a period challenged by a novel problem: information overload. Here's how the essay describes it:

"Books were a leading distraction in the early modern period—and how envious we should be of those times. From the 1500s onward, with the development of the printing press and the humanist revival of ancient philosophies, knowledge became available at a much greater pace than ever before."

This created pressing questions for aspiring thinkers, including: "How do we decide what to read? How long should we read it for? Must every single chapter be excerpted?"

Part of the solution was the development of "new note-taking techniques," including the copying of excerpts into a master notebook called a book of commonplaces. (For more on this technique, I recommend William Powell's delightful 2010 techno-history, *Hamlet's Blackberry*).

But as the essay on Steno elaborates, better notes weren't enough on their own, as there were simply too many good books available. In response to this reality, Steno, during his university studies in the 1650s, innovated some more advanced attention management strategies:

"[H]e learned to focus on specific themes, rather than letting his mind read multiple things quickly. A 'harmful hastening should be avoided' as he put it. His solution was to 'stick to one topic.'"

In practice, that meant blocking specific moments of time to go through the hardest tasks. As he wrote in his personal notebook, 'before noon nothing must be done except medical things.' ... As Steno told a friend, he took 'almost all the morning hours' to read the works of the Church Fathers and old biblical manuscripts available at the Medici library."

In other words, Steno created a method that combines what we might now call slow productivity , deep work , and time blocking .

The lessons here are clear. The use of our brains to think deeply about meaningful ideas isn't new. It's been at the core of the human experience since the early modern period, when access to sophisticated information first became somewhat widespread.

The best practices developed back then remain the best practices today: avoid overload, focus on one thing at a time, and block off specific hours in your day for your most mentally demanding efforts.

Two weeks ago, a small financial services firm, Citrini Research, published an essay describing a bleak scenario in which AI agents destroy the white-collar job market in the near future. The piece went viral and was cited as a factor in a modest decline of the S&P 500 the next day.

The Citrini essay wasn't the first to float this scenario. In recent weeks, there have been multiple credulous articles and op-eds in major publications proposing similar outcomes (e.g., 1 , 2 , and 3). But the negative impact on the stock market seems to have been the last straw for serious economists who began to push back on these technological ghost stories last week. (I particularly enjoyed a Deutsche Bank analyst who, perhaps borrowing some of my terminology, told the Times that the Citrini article had a "vibes-to-substance ratio" that was "undeniably high.")

If you're looking to reduce your blood pressure about this idea that AI is about to unravel the economy, I suggest reading a detailed response article published by an analyst from the Global Macro Strategies group at Citadel. It begins with a bit of finance geek sarcasm:

"Despite the macroeconomic community struggling to forecast 2-month-forward payroll growth with any reliable accuracy, the forward path of labor destruction can apparently be inferred with significant certainty from a hypothetical scenario posted on Substack..."

It then continues to systematically destabilize the economic naivety of these breathless op-eds and viral essays about how AI will dismantle the economy all at once. It certainly made me feel better.

(If you're looking for additional soothing of your AI anxiety, then you should also check the first episode of my new AI Reality Check podcast series, which I published last Thursday. I have a new episode of the series coming out this upcoming Thursday as well.)

The post *The Original Attention Crisis* appeared first on *Cal Newport* .

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An SAS Rescue Mission Mission Gone Wrong

Gavin Mortimer · HistoryNet

Norman Crockatt is not a well-known name, but the British intelligence officer was responsible for one of the most controversial decisions of World War II.

When the War Office in London created Military Intelligence Section 9 (MI9) on December 23, 1939, it chose the 45-year-old Crockatt to head the new organization. The former head of the London Stock Exchange, he was seen as “the right sort of chap” for the post despite his scant experience in military intelligence.

MI9’s mission was to help British military personnel escape and evade the enemy. That might mean smuggling maps and miniature compasses to prisoners of war held in Nazi camps or assisting shot-down airmen in enemy territory to evade capture and get back to Britain or Allied-controlled territory. MI9 was a small branch of British intelligence, but in June 1943 Crockatt had the responsibility of making a momentous decision about the fate of 80,000 Allied POWs incarcerated in Italian prison camps. The Allies were gearing up to invade Italy and Crockatt had to decide whether the POWs there should stay put and wait for the arrival of Allied troops or break out and try to make their own way to freedom.

Crockatt chose the former option, stating in an order issued on June 7, 1943, that “officers commanding prison camps will ensure that prisoners of war remain within camp. Authority is granted to all officers commanding to take necessary disciplinary action to prevent individual prisoners of war attempting to rejoin their own units.” Several factors influenced Crockatt’s final decision. First was the physical state of the prisoners, many of whom were believed to be malnourished after years in captivity. Then there was the prospect of tens of thousands of prisoners on the loose, providing easy targets for vengeful Nazis and fascist Italians loyal to Mussolini. Above all, Crockatt believed that the Allies’ advance north through Italy would be swift and British and American troops would quickly liberate the camps. Why risk a mass breakout and jeopardize the lives of so many men?

Lieutenant Colonel Charles “Tony” Simonds of the British A Force received orders to plan the rescue of prisoners of war who had escaped from their prison camps in Italy.

To get word to the POWs of what they should do, Crockatt used a secret code contained within the script of a popular BBC program, *The Radio Padre*, a favorite among the prisoners. But what MI9 didn’t do, remarkably, was inform British prime minister Winston Churchill or his War Cabinet of his decision. From the outset of negotiations with Italy Churchill had made plain his wish to see POWs returned to the Allies once the Armistice came into force. Article 3 of the Italian surrender agreement stipulated that prisoners were to be “immediately turned over to the Allied commander-in-chief and none of these may now or at any

time be evacuated to Germany.” When the Armistice was made public on September 8 the Italian War Ministry kept faith with its obligations and told 80,000 Allied prisoners that they were free to leave. But the majority remained in their camps, where they risked falling under the control of the Germans.

Churchill was aghast when he learned of Crockatt’s order for POWs to stay put, but by then it was too late for many prisoners. Contrary to what Crockatt had anticipated, the Germans had wasted little time in taking over most of the camps and were soon hunting the estimated 30,000 who had defied the stay-put command and taken flight.

Nothing could be done now to liberate the prisoners in the camps, but Churchill demanded a plan to rescue the fugitives. The man chosen to lead the operation was Lieutenant Colonel Charles “Tony” Simonds, who had joined MI9 in 1941 after fighting alongside General Orde Wingate in what is now Ethiopia. Based in Cairo, Simonds was in charge of A Force, which had responsibility to set up escape lines for Allied prisoners across occupied Europe. Summoned to Allied Forces HQ in Algiers on September 23, Simonds received orders to devise a plan to rescue the thousands of escaped Allied prisoners roaming Italy. He had at his disposal personnel from Britain’s 1st Airborne Division, Second Special Air Service Regiment (2SAS), and Special Operations Executive (SOE), as well as the American Office of Strategic Services (OSS). The mission received the code-name *Jonquil*.

In 1940 Bill established a training center at Lochailort, Scotland, where commandos could practice amphibious landings like those the SAS used for the POW rescue mission in Italy.

Simonds established his headquarters at Brindisi, a port on the eastern heel of the Italian boot, and arranged a meeting with officers from 2SAS, billeted 75 miles northwest in the coastal city of Bari. This elite British special forces unit had been formed in North Africa in 1941 by brothers David and Bill Stirling, and while stationed in Cairo Simonds had heard tales of their effectiveness in raiding Axis targets deep inside their territory. David Stirling had been captured in January 1943 but Bill, in command of 2SAS, sent two of his officers, Major Felix Symes and Captain Peter Power, to Brindisi to discuss the rescue operation.

They arrived on the evening of September 26 and for the next three hours Simonds briefed the SAS officers on the nature of the mission. Standing in front of a large map of the east coast of Italy, Simonds explained that he had divided the region into four areas, from Ancona in the north to Ortona in the south, a range of approximately 100 miles. Simonds defined the role of 2SAS in the operation thus: “In each area two parties will go in, one to be dropped by parachute inland, with the object of sending all P. W.s down to the coast, and one party to land by sea to form a beach party to guide, shepherd, and protect the prisoners, and also to supervise their embarkation after having signaled the boats.” There were seven soldiers in each party, and the

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standard-article(title: [Pierre Poilievre on the Role of Government, Freedom, and Affordability], author: [Vicky], source-name: [Farnam Street (fs.blog)], images: (), paragraphs: ([We released a special episode of TKP this week with Pierre Poilievre.], [While we don't often tackle politics on the show, we are trying to improve political discourse by offering a platform for both sides to speak with depth and nuance.], [What is the Role of Government?], [Second & Third Order Consequences], [Fighting for Canada Long Term], [What Role Does the Media Play?], [Maintaining Hope in Politics], [This episode covers the economy, media, free speech, immigration, corporate subsidies, and more. (And before you ask, the same invite was extended to both Pierre and Prime Minister Mark Carney).], [Available Now: Apple Podcasts | Spotify | YouTube | Transcript], [The post Pierre Poilievre on the Role of Government, Freedom, and Affordability appeared first on Farnam Street .],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 158, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

standard-article(title: [JUNKYARD PRINCESS], author: [Kirkus Reviews], source-name: [Kirkus Reviews], images: (), paragraphs: (["Four acres, steel fence, two warehouses, three forklifts, one-thousand cars, and a junkyard dog"; for the temperamental, uneducated Harry Saunders, his new wrecking yard in the desert was an empire to command. His 9-year-old daughter, Robyn, wrenched from suburban life in Laguna Beach, California, warmed up to it more slowly. She began working the junkyard counter as a tween, operating phone lines and locating parts despite knowing little about cars. Robyn was befriended by a rough posse of men, and Harry even let her drive a forklift once. But her little brother, Ryan, failed to thrive—he was savaged by the resident pack of guard dogs as a small child and later bonded with the ever-present tweakers selling scrap metal for meth funds. When the teenage Robyn salvaged a

standard-article(title: [Happy 1st Birthday, Atomic Habits! (plus 3 gifts for you...)], author: [James Clear], source-name: [James Clear (Atomic Habits)], images: (), paragraphs: ([One year ago today, Atomic Habits was born.], [The last 12 months have been a wild ride:], [1.1 million copies sold worldwide], [12 consecutive months on the New York Times best seller list (currently #3)], [Repeated appearances on the Audible, Wall Street Journal, and USA Today bestseller lists], [Over 20,000 reviews on Audible (4.8/5 stars)], [Over 1,300 reviews on Amazon (4.9/5 stars)], [Translated into 40+ languages (browse international editions)], [35+ keynote speeches in 13 countries], [...and so much more.], [I'm incredibly thankful for your support. I've been given so much this year and to celebrate Atomic Habits' 1st birthday, I put together 3 special bonuses for you.], [3 GIFTS FOR YOU], [I. Price drop.], [Now you can get my best work at a lower price. This week, Amazon dropped the price of Atomic Habits. If you've been thinking of grabbing a copy (for yourself or someone else), but haven't pulled the trigger yet, then right now is a great time to do it.], [You can currently get the hardcover for:], [40% off in the US], [33% off in the UK], [24% off in Canada], [International: 38% off worldwide (with free international shipping)], [The audio-book is also on sale through Audible .], [II. Special interview with Cal Newport.], [Cal Newport is the author of popular business books like Deep Work, Digital Minimalism, and So Good They Can't Ignore You. Many readers have told me that Cal's work pairs nicely with Atomic Habits.], [The two of us recently recorded a 1-hour discussion on topics like focus, habits, and productivity.], [], [III. Birthday Bundle!], [To finish off this special celebration, we partnered with Baron Fig to create a "birthday bundle" featuring some of our best habit-building products.], [The bundle includes:], [The Clear Habit Journal (now available in two sizes!)], [It's the ultimate habit-building package and makes a beautiful birthday or holiday gift.], [Finally, let me close by saying thank you and reaffirming my commitment to you and all of my readers.], [Time is precious. As always, I appreciate you sharing some of your day with me by reading my work. I will do my very best to send useful and valuable ideas your way.],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 377, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

standard-article(title: [A-MAZE-ING AIRPORT ADVENTURE], author: [Kirkus Reviews], source-name: [Kirkus Reviews], images: (), paragraphs: ([Munro, who knows her way around a maze, here fits a series of them into a simple storyline about a child who's taking a trip to visit Grandmother, accompanied by Mom and Dad. Written in second person addressed to readers, the book starts at Sunnyside Airport, and from there, we move—never in a straight line!—through departures, check-in, security, airport shops and the food court, and terminals into a wonderfully roomy plane interior. At last, it's time to take off: "UP, UP, AND AWAY!" Large, intricate, full-color spreads are rendered in Munro's familiar style, not drawn with super-sharp outlines but nevertheless perfectly clear.], [In addition to the winding mazes, each double-page spread includes a challenging list of items to find, including (on each spread) "a copy of

battered but stylish 1983 Honda Civic, her world opened.], [She listened to cool music on the radio and visited the ocean instead of attending school; away from the junkyard's chaotic orbit, she explored a more creative path. But as the business lost money, her father became increasingly ag-grieved, Ryan veered off course, and Robyn discovered that she could never fully escape her past. Saunders Wilson's "memoirella" is brief, but even when lightly touching on subjects like familial sexual abuse and drug addiction, her story has impact. The author's examination of her family and community grants grace and understanding to all. At restaurants, Harry harassed waitstaff, and the wrong word could cause him to flip over the dinner table at home—but his savagery obscured the early wound of abandonment.], [Ryan is a nemesis but also a confidant, wilding out with Robyn through the night and eating biscuits and gravy with her at dawn. The setting plays a pivotal role: Robyn left a safe "walled fortress" for a land of "misshapen" houses where the sky loses its "coastal blue tint," and nature—in the form of the Pacific Ocean and Cal State San Bernardino's forests—helped enable Robyn's eventual escape.],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 324, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

She listened to cool music on the radio and visited the ocean instead of attending school; away from the junkyard's chaotic orbit, she explored a more creative path.

Kirkus Reviews

In addition to the winding mazes, each double-page spread includes a challeng-ing list of items to find, including (on each spread) "a copy of this book.

Kirkus Reviews

standard-article(title: [WHERE I GREW], author: [Kirkus Reviews], source-name: [Kirkus Reviews], images: (), paragraphs: ([On the title page a pale-skinned adult clothed in colorful garb stands among a grayscale forest. As the main text starts, the adult—now aged but wearing a similar outfit —walks with a youngster, apparently a grandchild. Observ-ing and enjoying the vibrant, lush natural world around them, the narrator reflects on the different places the family has hailed from and paths they've taken "in search of the perfect place / To put down our roots / And call home." Over a few page turns, the child (revealed to be the book's narrator) has grown to adulthood and, donning the elder's satchel, explores the forest with the next generation. "I grew here. // This is my community." As the narrator's children (who present East Asian, like the narrator) swing among the trees and explore the forest, our narrator con-siders the past, present, and future.], [With spare but lyrical text, Awan's story celebrates a forest's transformation and that of a family over generations. Jomepour Bell's careful illustrations reveal the passage of time: what has changed (a single fox seen earlier eventually is depicted with two kits, a butterfly emerges from its chrysalis) and what remains: home and the vibrancy of the forest. The bright visual details reinforce the themes of belonging and time and reward attentive reading.],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 213, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

this book." Direct instructions ("After Security, you enter the FOOD COURT and SHOPS. First get a cold drink") guides readers through the mazes; an answer key keeps frustration at bay while providing useful and reassuring flying facts. The people depicted are diverse in terms of skin tone and ability; the protagonist never appears (the artwork is de-picted from the youngster's perspective). Whether prepar-ing for a trip or whiling away hours on a flight, readers will find this book absorbing and informative.],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 207, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

standard-article(title: [Be Your Best in 2026: The Most Important Lessons from The Knowledge Project (2025)], author: [Vicky], source-name: [Farnam Street (fs.blog)], im-ages: (), paragraphs: ([The Knowledge Project closes 2025 with a look back at the most meaningful conversations of the year. Featuring insights from some of our most impactful episodes, this collection brings together practi-cal insights on decision-making, leadership, preparation, relationships, trust, and performance.], [Alfred Lin: Inputs vs Outputs – Daily Routines and Priorities], [Bret Taylor: Founder Mode (Accountability vs. Caricature)], [Logan Ury: Navigating Relationships and Attachments], [Bill Belichick: Preparation and Success In Life And The NFL], [Indra Nooyi: Delivering a Message That Gets Heard], [Anthony Scilipoti: Don't Rely on AI, You Still Have to Put the Work In], [Lulu Cheng Meservey: Engineering Trust and Building Confidence That Others Can Believe In], [Harley Finkel-stein: Overcoming Failure + The Hard Work Behind the Life You Want], [Jim Murphy: Performance Habits of Successful People], [This episode features insights from world-class investor Alfred Lin , tech founder and operator Bret Taylor , behavioral scientist Logan Ury , legendary NFL coach Bill Belichick , former PepsiCo CEO Indra Nooyi , disciplined value investor Anthony Scilipoti , trust and communication expert Lulu Cheng Meservey , Shopify President Harley Finkelstein , and performance coach Jim Murphy .], [These

are the insights that help you prepare better, make clearer decisions, and build momentum for the year ahead.], [Thank you for listening and being part of The Knowledge Project this year.], [Available Now: Apple Podcasts | Spotify | YouTube | Transcript], [The post Be Your Best in 2026: The Most Important Lessons from The Knowledge Project (2025) appeared first on Farnam Street .],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 300, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

standard-article(title: [THE HEART WORK OF MODERN LEADERSHIP], author: [Kirkus Reviews], source-name: [Kirkus Reviews], images: (), paragraphs: (["The work of leadership isn't just about building organizations," writes Grossman; "it's about building people who then create something extraordinary together." Drawing on the "collective wisdom" of his clients and colleagues in the business sector, as well as data amassed by the Harris Poll on behalf of his consulting agency, the author argues that the most effective modern leaders balance "emotional intelligence with analytical thinking." In other words, they combine an empathetic, encouraging approach with strategic thinking focused on efficiency. While the book's ample selection of anecdotes from CEOs across numerous businesses lend a personal touch to the work, what stands out most is the poll data taken from more than 2,000 employees.], [This research indicates the persistence of antiquated "command-and-control" leadership styles, with only one-third of employees willing to call their organization's leadership "exceptional." Grossman convincingly uses the Harris Poll data to identify six traits characteristic of exceptional leaders and devotes an entire chapter to each, including leading with gratitude, fostering an inclusive culture, and "communicat[ing] with context." (The author reports that leaders designated exceptional by their employees were more than seven times more effective at "adjusting their communication to meet employee needs.") Grossman conveys his research-backed claims in an enthusiastic writing style that makes for an absorbing read rich with real-world examples and commentary from the author's corporate cohorts.], [The book boasts a wealth of visual elements, such as colorful fonts and high-resolution, full-color illustrations, diagrams, and photographs; occasionally, the work feels like a stimulating collection of streamlined infographics. It also reads at times like an extended advertisement for the author's consulting agency, the Grossman Group, since the text is full of trademarked phrases, references to the author's other books, and QR codes linked to additional products and services.],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 291, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

standard-article(title: [WHO NEEDS FRIENDS], author: [Kirkus Reviews], source-name: [Kirkus Reviews], images: (), paragraphs: ([Actor-turned-author McCarthy, now in his 60s, begins with a comment from a young son who says, offhandedly, "You don't really have any friends, do you, Dad?" McCarthy thinks, well, he has friends, but he doesn't see them often. The resolve, then, that drives this narrative was to go seek out friends from his hell-raising, bibulous youth and beyond, driving up and down and across the continent to check in. One visit was to a man he called his "surrogate big brother," who had fallen on hard times, psychically speaking; though that old friend waved him off, McCarthy drove the many miles to see him all the same, to find him living as a hoarder with boxes everywhere that explained, McCarthy gamely writes, "how Jeff Bezos became a billionaire." A modest intervention ensues before McCarthy pushes on.], [Friends can be as numerous as one wishes, but they require investment: McCarthy cites a study that conjectures that "it takes two hundred hours to make a good friend." Making is one thing, keeping quite another: He marvels at an encounter in a Texas diner with a group of women who meet for lunch every Wednesday and have for time immemorial, which causes him to wonder, "Why are women just so much better at this?" The answers are various. McCarthy notes, near the end of his narrative, that while he's met many men who have had friends for decades, he has also met "men who have no male friends at all, who can't even conceive of the idea." McCarthy finds hope for those friendless men when he concludes that those with whom he's spoken allow that they'd "just never talked about this before" and might ponder doing something about], [it.],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 286, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

While the book's ample selection of anecdotes from CEOs across numerous businesses lend a personal touch to the work, what stands out most is the poll data taken from more than 2,000 employees.

Kirkus Reviews

standard-article(title: [BENEATH], author: [Kirkus Reviews], source-name: [Kirkus Reviews], images: (), paragraphs: ([For six years Sasha has lived in Haven, the underground society built to withstand nuclear war. Since the

standard-article(title: [ON THE RECORD], author: [Kirkus Reviews], source-name: [Kirkus Reviews], images: (), paragraphs: ([It's typically American, Johns Hopkins musicologist Celenza notes, that rebelling colonials adopted the

war, since her family's deaths, since discovering she doesn't get sick like everyone else does, Sasha's life has been full of death and overfull with grief. While working in the Ward, Haven's limited hospital, she stays with patients as they die. When Tristian Hayes, a unit commander of the Force, ends up as her patient, hanging on for his life, she pleads for him to stay alive. He does—upending her bleak ritual as Death's Angel. Hoping to forget everything she's seen and to numb the pain, Sasha leaves the Ward in favor of a role with a pickax, expanding Haven's tunnels. Tristian, fiercely determined and stunningly stubborn, recruits Sasha to the Force for a vital mission aboveground.], [The story picks up steam with Sasha's intense training to become the medic for Tristian's tightknit unit. Together, they bear the weight of their unit's survival and all that's left of humankind. While in training, Sasha struggles to discern friends and enemies, but nothing is as challenging as facing her own demons. In this prequel to her debut novel, *Conform* (2025), Sullivan tries to accomplish a lot with both the worldbuilding and plot machinations, resulting in a convoluted story and flat-tened characters. The plot doesn't have a satisfying payoff, but the romantic tension between Sasha and Tristian will keep readers engaged.],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 236, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

standard-article(title: [THE HEART OF OUR HOME], author: [Kirkus Reviews], source-name: [Kirkus Reviews], images: (), paragraphs: ([The table is where this loving Black family enjoys the first meal of the day; it's where the children do homework and make cookies and where everyone prepares for fish fry Fridays. Extended family shares space here during somber moments, such as deaths, and on happier occasions, including birthdays, Kwanzaa, and other holidays. Grandpa regales the young protagonist (who narrates) with stories of Mom and Dad's past as the child listens intently. And when it's time for Mom to braid the youngster's hair, this, too, happens at the table. "The process is exhausting for both of us, and I sometimes struggle to sit still," but "when she is finished, I feel so pretty—and thankful that it's done." In her authorial debut, Washington relies on the cut-paper collage technique that won her a Caldecott Honor for *Choosing Brave* (2022), written by Angela], [Joy. Her images boast bright colors, rich textures (the grain of the wooden table is particularly eye-catching), and a level of detail so intricate, it's hard to believe the artist relied on cut paper alone. Her straightforward prose often ripples across the page, conveying warmth and visual verve. Photos of Washington's own family table close out the work.],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 199, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

derisive British song "Yankee Doodle" as a badge of pride. But a true anthem was wanted, and it came in the War of 1812 (which "we tend to forget...began as an act of US aggression"): the "Star-Spangled Banner," written by a lawyer (and slaveholder in the "land of the free") who borrowed the barely singable tune from a British men's club. It might have been a handier ditty, such as "My Country 'Tis of Thee" (its tune borrowed from "God Save the King") or "Hail, Columbia," but alas, no. Not long after emancipation, the formerly enslaved and their descendants found an anthem of their own in "Lift Every Voice and Sing," with its resonant cadences ("Lift every voice and sing / Till earth and heaven ring, / Ring with the harmonies of], [Liberty..."), a song that deserves wider circulation outside the African American church community. Other songs in Celenza's roster speak to other aspirations of freedom: George Gershwin's "Rhapsody in Blue," which "captured the mechanistic beat of modern life"; the collected works of Duke Ellington, blending jazz with the European classical tradition; Abel Meeropol's anti-lynching ballad "Strange Fruit" as sung by the great Billie Holiday, who ended her set with it and left the stage immediately after, leaving her audiences stunned by the force of her delivery; Jerome Robbins' musical *West Side Story*, originally meant to tell the story of immigrant Eastern European Jews in New York and seized upon by politicians to denounce juvenile delinquency; and of course that great delinquent Bob Dylan, whose folk anthem "Blowin' in the Wind,"], [Celenza wryly notes, offers "an answer that is equally evasive and profound," like the author himself. Celenza's selections, extending into the era of Hamilton, aren't unexpected, but she has something fresh to say about all of them.],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 313, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

standard-article(title: [[Outliers] The Multidisciplinary Approach to Thinking | Peter D. Kaufman], author: [Vicky], source-name: [Farnam Street (fs.blog)], images: (), paragraphs: ([One of the people I've learned the most from is Peter D. Kaufman.], [Peter has been the chairman and CEO of GlenAir since 1977. And he's got a track record that puts him in the top 0.001% of business leaders during that time. He's also the editor of *Poor Charlie's Almanack* and was one of Charlie Munger's closest friends for decades.], [In a talk never meant to be made public, he revealed the secrets of multidisciplinary thinking. Someone unfortunately recorded the talk without his permission. It became hugely popular, and eventually Peter allowed the complete talk to be transcribed and posted on FS.], [It's time to listen and learn.], [Available Now: Apple Podcasts | Spotify | X | Transcript], [+ Dive deeper into Mental Models.], [The post [Outliers] The Multidisciplinary Approach to Thinking | Peter D. Kaufman appeared first on Farnam Street .],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 144, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

standard-article(title: [This Quiet Missionary Survived the Lincoln County War to Live Among the Zunis], author: [Gregory Lalire], source-name: [HistoryNet], images: (), paragraphs: ([The Rev. Dr. Taylor Filmore Ealy faced many struggles, most not of his own making, while a Presbyterian medical missionary between 1874 and 1881—first at Fort Arbuckle, on the Chickasaw Reservation in Oklahoma Territory; then in volatile Lincoln, New Mexico Territory; and finally at Zuni Pueblo, also in New Mexico Territory. Some of that time he kept a journal. Daughter Ruth drew on his journal entries, as well as the recollections and correspondence of her father and mother, Mary, to write *Water in a Thirsty Land*—first privately issued in 1955 in a limited edition of 40 copies.], [Editor David Thomas resurrects the Ealy chronicle as Vol. 10 of Doc45’s Mesilla Valley History series. In his excellent introduction Thomas provides not only overviews of the three Western locales where the Ealys lived, but also brief biographies of the major figures in Ruth’s narrative. Perhaps of greatest interest is the time the Ealys spent in Lincoln, as the family arrived on the day murdered English rancher John Tunstall’s body was brought into town. It was the latter’s murder that triggered the 1878 Lincoln County War, and it was the Rev. Dr. Ealy who delivered Tunstall’s funeral oration at the home of Alexander McSween. Forty-one days later the doctor and family witnessed the killing of Lincoln County Sheriff William Brady and Deputy George Hindman, and the Ealys were also present for the five-day shootout in Lincoln that culminated with the burning of the McSween house and Alexander’s murder. In his journal Ealy noted that Colonel Nathan Dudley, the commander at Fort Stanton, “refused to protect McSween and ordered his men not to fire over Dudley’s camp, or he would turn the cannon on them. My wife read his note to reply to McSween’s request for protection. McSween’s house, where his party had taken refuge, was deliberately set on fire.”], [Such violence is what ultimately drove the family out of Lincoln. The Rev. Dr. Ealy then spent nearly three years as a missionary teacher at Zuni Pueblo, 150 miles west of Albuquerque. There was no gunplay there, but Ealy experienced plenty of cultural shock. “He had gained the respect of many of the Indians who more and more were beginning to realize the value of an education,” wrote Ruth (who was born in East Waterford, Pa., in 1877 and died in St. Petersburg, Fla., in 1959). “The religious dances still interfered with the school attendance, it is true, but the children seemed to be enjoying their school-work. He had learned to like his Indian friends.” It was—and remains—mighty dry country, and Ealy often noted in his journal how the Zunis danced day and night for rain.], [By Ruth R. Ealy, edited by David Thomas, Doc45 Publishing, 2022], [If you buy something through our site, we might earn a commission.],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 489, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

standard-article(title: [What Do Social Media Companies Fear? Time Management.], author: [Study Hacks], source-name: [Study Hacks (Cal Newport)], images: (), paragraphs: ([I recently came across an interesting academic article in the journal *Frontiers in Psychology*. It was titled, “The relationships between social media use, time management, and decision-making styles.”], [The paper’s author surveyed 612 university students and young adults, asking them,

standard-article(title: [Joe Liemandt: Alpha School and the Future of Education], author: [Vicky], source-name: [Farnam Street (fs.blog)], images: (), paragraphs: ([Joe Liemandt is the principal of Alpha School and the founder of Trilogy Software and ESW Capital.], [Liemandt dropped out of Stanford to build Trilogy, made the cover of *Forbes* twice before thirty, became the youngest member of the *Forbes* 400, then vanished from public life for twenty-five years. But he didn’t stop building. Through ESW Capital, he quietly became one of the most prolific acquirers of software businesses in the world.], [Now he’s back with a \$1 billion bet that AI can make kids learn ten times faster, and that school as we know it isn’t just inefficient, it’s broken.], [Coming Soon: YouTube | Spotify | Apple Podcasts | Transcript], [At Alpha School, students spend two hours a day on AI-driven instruction and score in the top 1% on standardized tests. The rest of the day is devoted to what Liemandt calls life skills: leadership, entrepreneurship, teamwork, and real projects that kids actually care about.], [There are no lectures, and kids don’t move forward until they master the material.], [He argues the traditional classroom was designed for a narrow slice of students and wastes everyone else’s time. The fix isn’t more money or better teachers; it’s rebuilding from scratch around mastery, motivation, and AI.], [This conversation covers his full arc from sleeping on the floor at Trilogy to being mentored by Jack Welch, to deciding that “kids must love school more than vacation” was a non-negotiable design principle.], [He explains how Timeback works under the hood, why he’s comfortable streaming student screens to AI in real time, and how he plans to scale it for a billion kids.], [I hope you enjoy this conversation as much as I did.], [The post Joe Liemandt: Alpha School and the Future of Education appeared first on Farnam Street .],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 316, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

standard-article(title: [PEN PALS], author: [Kirkus Reviews], source-name: [Kirkus Reviews], images: (), paragraphs: ([Having established in the opener that being “Poetry Pals” is far better than being predator and prey, Coelophysis and Frog set off to see the world and learn to write about it. They start by alternating spontaneous rhyming lines, advance to two-word poems that they dub “Blue Poos,” and finish up with “sound poems” created with

among other things, about their digital habits and levels of personal organization. Using a linear regression analysis, she uncovered the following:], [“Social media use was negatively and significantly associated with overall time management and all its subscales.”], [Here’s the standard interpretation of this result: Social media is distracting, and if you’re distracted, it becomes harder to maintain control over your schedule. So, the more you use social media, the worse you become at time management.], [But I’ve become interested in the reverse form of this argument: the better your planning system, the less time you’ll spend on engagement-based applications like social media .], [Here’s my thinking...], [When you’re following an intentional schedule, your efforts are oriented toward goals that you find important. You also feel a satisfying sense of self-efficacy. These realities engage your long-term reward system, which can override the urges generated by its short-term counterpart, dissipating the drive for quick gratification from activities like glancing at your phone.], [In other words: The more you organize your analog life, the less appealing you’ll find the digital alternative.], [If this is true, then maybe the thing social media companies fear most is not some newly-powerful application-blocking software or impossibly strict regulation, but rather a good old-fashioned daily planner.], [A lot of people I know have been freaked out recently by a viral essay with a grandiose title: “Something Big is Happening.” I recently released a short video in which I conduct a close analysis of this piece. (Spoiler alert: I wasn’t impressed.) Check it out.], [(More generally, I’ve been considering starting a separate weekly podcast/newsletter dedicated to providing a reality check on recent AI news. It feels like it might be useful to separate this discussion from my existing podcast and newsletter, which are more focused on how individuals can seek depth in a distracted world. But also, maybe this is a bad idea? I’m interested to hear your thoughts about this plan.)], [The post What Do Social Media Companies Fear? Time Management. appeared first on Cal Newport .],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 386, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

a chorus of hooting, honking Parasaurolophus. Along the way, a supposedly bad—but really funny—poem (“How does a T-Rex pick his nose? / Arms too short, so he uses his toes!”) leads to a frantic flight from its irate subject, while an Archeopteryx named Hope drops in and out of view to fuel bits of wordplay and a wistful concrete poem from smitten Coelophysis: “I hope / to see / Hope / soon / and / hopefully / Hope / hopes / what I / hope.” Like the poems, the illustrations seem both simple and unpolished at first], [and, OK, second glances. But the hand-lettered verses and the googly-eyed dinos, both of which Angleberger places on layered swatches of creased and deckle-edged paper for a 3-D look, carry more than enough vim to leave budding poets roaring to join this brand-new writer’s group in its collective closing “ALL RIGHT!!!! Let’s WRITE!!!!”],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 206, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

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